ECONOMIC INTELLIGENCE SERIES

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · April 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Kansas City	74.3
#2	A+	Raleigh	72.4
#3	A+	Hartford	68.6
#4	A+	Las Vegas	68.2
#5	A	Austin	65.4
#6	A	Birmingham	64.2
#7	A	Salt Lake City	63.8

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Portland	22.8
#49	C-	Washington DC	28.7
#48	C-	Baltimore	29.6
#47	C-	Richmond	30.7
#46	C-	Jacksonville	31.9
#45	C	Chicago	34.3
#44	C	Minneapolis	34.6

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	9 cities
B+ / B / B-	23 cities
C+ / C / C-	17 cities
D	1 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, CLF Growth, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · April 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	**Kansas City** Kansas City	A+	74.3	3.5%	+7.0%	+1.4%	+2.1%	45 days
2	**Raleigh** Raleigh-Cary	A+	72.4	3.0%	+4.0%	+1.7%	+0.5%	46 days
3	**Hartford** Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A+	68.6	2.7%	+0.1%	+1.9%	+2.8%	39 days
4	**Las Vegas** Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	A+	68.2	5.2%	+6.7%	+1.7%	+3.2%	52 days
5	**Austin** Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A	65.4	3.2%	+5.8%	+1.4%	+1.0%	53 days
6	**Birmingham** Birmingham	A	64.2	2.2%	-0.5%	+0.5%	+1.1%	56 days
7	**Salt Lake City** Salt Lake City-Murray	A	63.8	3.4%	+4.0%	+0.7%	+0.6%	45 days
8	**Dallas** Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	A-	62.9	3.6%	+4.4%	+1.0%	+0.6%	48 days
9	**Nashville** Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A-	61.7	3.0%	+2.3%	+0.4%	+3.4%	53 days
10	**Pittsburgh** Pittsburgh	B+	57.9	3.6%	+7.0%	+0.3%	+0.7%	65 days
11	**Los Angeles** Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B+	55.5	4.8%	+5.4%	+1.8%	+0.7%	45 days
12	**San Francisco** San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B+	55.0	4.1%	+5.5%	+0.7%	+0.4%	29 days
13	**Houston** Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B	54.9	4.2%	+4.1%	+0.7%	+0.9%	50 days
14	**Cincinnati** Cincinnati	B	54.9	3.6%	+0.6%	+0.3%	-0.8%	45 days
15	**Atlanta** Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	B	54.2	N/A	+6.5%	N/A	+0.5%	51 days
16	**Denver** Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B	54.0	3.6%	+4.7%	-0.1%	-1.5%	38 days
17	**Fresno** Fresno	B	53.4	8.2%	+8.4%	+1.9%	+1.9%	51 days
18	**Memphis** Memphis	B	53.2	4.0%	+6.1%	-0.3%	+1.4%	62 days
19	**San Jose** San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	B	51.7	4.0%	+0.7%	+1.7%	+0.8%	24 days
20	**New York** New York Newark-Jersey City	B	50.7	4.5%	+5.5%	+0.1%	+1.2%	51 days
21	**Charlotte** Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	B	50.4	3.6%	-1.3%	+0.8%	+2.3%	49 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
22	**San Diego** San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	B	50.3	4.4%	+4.6%	+0.7%	+1.7%	38 days
23	**Miami** Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B-	49.5	3.5%	+8.4%	-0.7%	+1.4%	74 days
24	**Columbus** Columbus	B-	49.4	3.6%	+3.0%	+0.3%	+0.3%	41 days
25	**Cleveland** Cleveland	B-	49.0	3.4%	-0.8%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
26	**Philadelphia** Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B-	48.3	N/A	N/A	+0.3%	+0.9%	43 days
27	**Phoenix** Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	B-	48.1	3.5%	N/A	-0.3%	N/A	54 days
28	**Providence** Providence-Warwick	B-	48.1	4.3%	+2.8%	+0.6%	+1.7%	48 days
29	**Louisville** Louisville-Jefferson County	B-	47.4	3.1%	+2.4%	-0.2%	+0.4%	45 days
30	**Riverside** Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	B-	44.8	5.1%	+6.7%	+0.9%	+1.1%	54 days
31	**Seattle** Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B-	44.2	5.0%	+9.0%	-0.1%	-0.7%	34 days
32	**Sacramento** Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	B-	44.2	4.8%	+3.0%	+1.0%	+1.2%	39 days
33	**San Antonio** San Antonio-New Braunfels	C+	43.7	3.7%	+3.4%	+0.4%	+1.5%	61 days
34	**Tampa** Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	C+	43.3	4.6%	+8.8%	-0.2%	+0.8%	66 days
35	**Oklahoma City** Oklahoma City	C+	42.5	3.6%	+5.4%	-0.5%	+0.2%	55 days
36	**Indianapolis** Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C+	42.0	2.5%	+4.0%	-0.7%	-0.4%	51 days
37	**Grand Rapids** Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	C+	41.4	4.0%	+3.9%	-0.4%	-5.0%	44 days
38	**Orlando** Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	C+	40.1	4.4%	N/A	+0.5%	N/A	67 days
39	**St. Louis** St. Louis	C+	38.8	3.5%	+1.4%	+0.2%	+1.0%	46 days
40	**Boston** Boston-Cambridge-Newton	C+	38.1	3.9%	+3.4%	N/A	N/A	30 days
41	**Virginia Beach** Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C	37.7	3.6%	+10.1%	-0.4%	-2.4%	36 days
42	**Milwaukee** Milwaukee-Waukesha	C	35.5	3.1%	+3.5%	-0.8%	-3.1%	33 days
43	**Detroit** Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C	35.2	4.7%	+1.6%	-0.2%	+0.6%	45 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
44	**Minneapolis** Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C	34.6	N/A	+1.5%	-0.1%	+0.6%	36 days
45	**Chicago** Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C	34.3	4.5%	+4.0%	+0.3%	-1.7%	35 days
46	**Jacksonville** Jacksonville	C-	31.9	4.6%	+6.4%	-0.5%	+0.8%	58 days
47	**Richmond** Richmond	C-	30.7	3.3%	+5.4%	-0.4%	-1.2%	39 days
48	**Baltimore** Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	C-	29.6	3.6%	+3.0%	-1.5%	-0.6%	37 days
49	**Washington DC** Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	C-	28.7	3.8%	+1.9%	N/A	-1.8%	N/A
50	**Portland** Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	D	22.8	4.9%	+5.0%	-1.8%	+0.0%	49 days

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #1 OF 50

Kansas City

Kansas City

A+

EXCELLENT

74.3th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	96
Unemployment	20% weight	60
Wage Growth	15% weight	85
Cost of Living	12% weight	76
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	89
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	62
Housing Access	5% weight	4
Office Economy	3% weight	38

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.5%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+7.0%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.4%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+2.1%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+5.4%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **45 days** median, -11.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 74.3th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score of 7.32, and its strong wage growth, at 6.97% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with a thriving job market and increasing worker purchasing power.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's employment growth rate is 1.39% year-over-year, combined with a 1.070% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a healthy and growing economy. This trend suggests that businesses can expect to find a strong and engaged workforce.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate is 3.50%, placing it near the median at the 60th percentile. This rate indicates a relatively balanced market, neither too tight nor too slack, which means that businesses may face some competition for talent, but it is still possible to hire without excessive wage pressure. However, this also means that local consumer demand is likely to be stable, supporting a wide range of business activities.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Kansas City is 6.97% year-over-year, which is considered fast. This rapid wage growth implies that employer labor costs are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can benefit businesses that rely on local consumer spending. As wages continue to grow, businesses may need to adjust their pricing strategies to remain competitive.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $200/sqft to $35.19/hr, Kansas City ranks at the 76th percentile in terms of affordability. This means that the city is more affordable than many of its peers, which can be a significant advantage for talent attraction, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living. This affordability can help attract and retain workers without breaking the bank.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Kansas City is growing at a rate of 2.10% year-over-year, indicating that the workforce supply is expanding. This growth suggests that businesses will have access to a increasing pool of potential employees, making it easier to hire and staff new positions. As the labor force continues to grow, businesses can expect to find the talent they need to expand their operations.

Building Permits

The city has seen a 5.41% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, which signals that housing supply is expanding. This expansion is likely to improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce, making it easier for businesses to attract and retain talent. As housing supply increases, the city is likely to remain an attractive location for workers and businesses alike.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Kansas City is 45 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 11.8%. This fast-paced market means that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, this also indicates a strong and competitive real estate market, which can be a draw for businesses looking to attract top talent.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share ranks at the 38th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This means that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep pool of tech, finance, or consulting talent, but it may be more attractive to industries with different workforce needs. Businesses that can thrive in a more diverse economic environment may find Kansas City an appealing location.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, fast wage growth, and affordability, making it an attractive location for a wide range of industries. However, the city's fast-paced housing market and relatively shallow professional talent pool are factors that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Kansas City as a potential business location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #2 OF 50

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A+

EXCELLENT

72.4th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	92
Unemployment	20% weight	81
Wage Growth	15% weight	43
Cost of Living	12% weight	80
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	36
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	85
Housing Access	5% weight	43
Office Economy	3% weight	98

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.0%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+4.0%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+1.7%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	**+0.5%**	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	**+38.8%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**46 days**	median, +4.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 72.4th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 6.66, and its high share of office and professional workers, at 98th percentile. These metrics signal a city with a thriving job market and a deep talent pool.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has seen employment growth of 1.70% year-over-year, combined with a slight deviation in weekly hours of -0.025% from its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs while hours worked are slightly below trend, indicating a healthy and sustainable labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.66 is in the top tier, at the 92nd percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary is 3.00%, which is in the top tier at the 81st percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with relatively low slack, making it more challenging for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive compensation packages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Raleigh-Cary is 3.97%, which is near the median at the 43rd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, while workers are seeing some improvement in their purchasing power. However, the relatively slow wage growth may not be sufficient to keep pace with the cost of living in the area.

Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living score in the top tier at the 80th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $218/sqft to $37.79/hr, or 5.77. The fact that the PSF is falling by 1.4% year-over-year relative to wages makes the city more affordable. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as companies may not need to offer large wage premiums to compensate for the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary is growing at a rate of 0.53% year-over-year, which is below average at the 36th percentile. This slow growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, but at a relatively slow pace, which may pose some challenges for hiring capacity in the long term.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Raleigh-Cary has increased by 38.82% year-over-year, which is in the top tier at the 85th percentile. This significant growth in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate the growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is 46 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.5%. This near-median performance at the 43rd percentile indicates a relatively competitive market, but still accessible for workers relocating to the area. The rising days on market may signal a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

The office and professional worker share in Raleigh-Cary is exceptionally high, at the 98th percentile. This deep talent pool makes the city an ideal location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a thriving job market, a deep talent pool, and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the slow labor force growth rate poses a potential risk, as it may limit the city's ability to accommodate rapid expansion or large-scale hiring initiatives, making it essential for decision-makers to factor this constraint into their location decisions.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #3 OF 50

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A+

EXCELLENT

68.6th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	98
Unemployment	20% weight	94
Wage Growth	15% weight	6
Cost of Living	12% weight	48
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	94
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	32
Housing Access	5% weight	98
Office Economy	3% weight	43

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	2.7%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+2.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-12.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	39 days	median, +30.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 68.6th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 98th percentile, driven by strong employment growth and hours worked above trend. Specifically, the employment growth rate of +1.88% and weekly hours deviation of +0.495% signal genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The combination of +1.88% employment growth and +0.495% weekly hours deviation above trend indicates a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This suggests that the city is experiencing a surge in job creation, with workers putting in more hours to meet the increasing demand. As a result, businesses can expect a competitive environment for talent, with a high likelihood of finding skilled workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 2.70% is exceptionally low, ranking in the 94th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding available workers, and wage pressure is likely to be high. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.13% is relatively stagnant, ranking in the 6th percentile. This slow wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not increasing rapidly, but worker purchasing power may be limited. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the same level of disposable income to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $252/sqft to $39.59/hr, ranking in the 48th percentile, the city is near the median in terms of affordability. However, the fact that PSF is falling by -1.6% YoY relative to wages suggests that the city is becoming more affordable. This means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +2.77% year-over-year, ranking in the 94th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. This suggests that businesses will have access to a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier to find and hire talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -12.70%, ranking in the 32nd percentile, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This suggests that the city may face future affordability challenges and potential workforce accommodation constraints, which could impact businesses' ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of +30.0%, ranking in the 98th percentile. This indicates a slower market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as they will have more time to find a suitable home. However, this may also suggest a normalization of the market after a period of rapid growth.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share ranking in the 43rd percentile, the city has a near-median depth of professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for a variety of businesses, but may not be as attractive to tech, finance, or consulting firms that require a highly specialized workforce.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, low unemployment, and a growing workforce supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for future affordability challenges and workforce accommodation constraints due to the tightening housing supply, which could impact businesses' ability to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #4 OF 50

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

A+

EXCELLENT

68.2th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	94
Unemployment	20% weight	30
Wage Growth	15% weight	81
Cost of Living	12% weight	52
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	96
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	45
Housing Access	5% weight	76
Office Economy	3% weight	85

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+3.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-9.8%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	52 days	median, +18.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 68.2th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a composite score of 6.73, and its strong labor force growth, at 3.24% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with a thriving job market and an expanding workforce.

Labor Demand

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has seen employment growth of 1.70% year-over-year, combined with a 0.049% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth, indicating that the labor market is strong and workers are in high demand. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or establish operations in the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area is 5.20%, which is below average, ranking at the 30th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, which can make it harder for businesses to hire and may lead to upward pressure on wages. As a result, businesses may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area is 6.67%, which is relatively fast, ranking at the 81st percentile. This rapid wage growth may lead to rising labor costs for employers, but it also indicates strong worker purchasing power, which can be beneficial for businesses that rely on local consumer demand. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs when making location decisions.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area is near median, with a percentile rank of 52nd, and a price-to-salary ratio of $265/sqft to $32.64/hr, or 8.12. The fact that the PSF is falling by 1.9% year-over-year is a key driver of the city's affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage, as businesses may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area is growing at a rate of 3.24% year-over-year, which is relatively fast, ranking at the 96th percentile. This expanding labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract and retain talent in this market.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has decreased by 9.83% year-over-year, which is a relatively sharp decline, ranking at the 45th percentile. This decline in building permits may signal a tightening of the housing supply, which could lead to future affordability challenges and make it harder for workers to relocate to the area. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of a tightening housing market on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area is 52 days, which is relatively fast, with a year-over-year increase of 18.2%, ranking at the 76th percentile. This indicates a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the rising days on market may also signal a healthy normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 85th. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, which require a different type of workforce.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a strong labor market, expanding workforce, and relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the potential tightening of the housing market, which could lead to future affordability challenges and make it harder to attract and retain talent. As a result, businesses should carefully consider the potential impact of the housing market on their location decision.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #5 OF 50

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A

VERY GOOD

65.4th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	57
Unemployment	20% weight	77
Wage Growth	15% weight	72
Cost of Living	12% weight	94
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	62
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	11
Housing Access	5% weight	71
Office Economy	3% weight	96

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-29.4%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	53 days	median, +20.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 65.4th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low unemployment rate of 3.20% and high wage growth of 5.84%. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, which signal a tight labor market with rising labor costs. Specifically, the unemployment rate ranks in the 77th percentile, and the wage growth rate ranks in the 72nd percentile.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 1.36% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -1.509% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate labor demand expansion, as the city is adding jobs, but the hours worked are slightly below trend. The labor demand composite score of 4.70 ranks in the 57th percentile, indicating a near-median labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 3.20%, ranking in the 77th percentile, which indicates a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have strong bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 5.84%, ranking in the 72nd percentile, which indicates fast wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but workers also have increasing purchasing power. The strong wage growth suggests that businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but also benefits from a workforce with growing disposable income.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is relatively affordable, with a percentile rank of 94th, driven by a PSF of $241/sqft, which is decreasing by 7.0% year-over-year, and an hourly wage of $37.93. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live and work in the area without requiring significant wage premiums. The affordable cost of living is a major draw for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is growing at a rate of 1.01% year-over-year, ranking in the 62nd percentile, which indicates a moderate expansion of the workforce supply. This means that businesses have a growing pool of potential workers to hire from, making it easier to find talent. The positive labor force growth rate suggests that the city has a strong foundation for future economic growth.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos has decreased by 29.44% year-over-year, ranking in the 11th percentile, which indicates a tightening of the housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the city's housing stock is not expanding to meet demand. The sharp decline in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a growing and affordable workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 53 days, with a year-over-year increase of 20.4%, ranking in the 71st percentile. This means that the housing market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The rising days on market suggests that the city's housing market is normalizing, making it easier for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is 4.59, ranking in the 96th percentile, which indicates a deep and specialized talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses. The strong office economy suggests that businesses that require specialized knowledge workers will find a rich talent pool in the city.

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, rising wages, and an affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for businesses that require specialized knowledge workers. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the tightening housing supply, which may impact future affordability and workforce accommodation, and should be carefully considered in any location decision.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #6 OF 50

Birmingham

Birmingham

A

VERY GOOD

64.2th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	88
Unemployment	20% weight	98
Wage Growth	15% weight	4
Cost of Living	12% weight	26
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	66
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	92
Housing Access	5% weight	31
Office Economy	3% weight	53

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	2.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-0.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+55.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	56 days	median, +3.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 64.2th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and low unemployment rate defining its current economic character, at 88th and 98th percentiles, respectively. The labor demand composite score of 6.28, driven by a 0.52% employment growth rate and a 1.249% deviation in weekly hours above trend, signals a genuine demand expansion. This combination of metrics suggests a city with a growing economy and increasing labor needs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.52% and weekly hours deviation of 1.249% above trend indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.28 further reinforces this notion, placing Birmingham in the top tier of labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 2.20% is extremely low, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified workers, as the pool of available labor is limited. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of -0.46% is stagnant, indicating that labor costs are not rising rapidly. However, this also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing, which could have implications for local consumer demand. Employers may benefit from a flat cost environment, but workers may not see significant improvements in their standard of living.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 26th, Birmingham is relatively expensive, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $160/sqft to $32.53/hr, or 4.92. This suggests that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage without offering wage premiums. However, the fact that PSF is rising 1.3% YoY relative to wages may indicate that affordability is decreasing over time.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 1.06% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests that there will be a growing pool of available workers in the future. However, the growth rate is not extremely high, so companies may still face some challenges in finding qualified talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is 55.25%, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is high, and the city is likely to see an increase in available housing stock in the future. As a result, affordability may improve, and the city may become more attractive to relocating workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 56 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.7%. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down slightly, making it more accessible to relocating workers. However, the market is still relatively competitive, and workers may face some challenges in finding available housing.

Office Economy

With an office economy percentile rank of 53rd, Birmingham has a near-median depth of professional talent pool, suggesting that it is suited for a variety of business types, but may not be ideal for companies requiring extremely specialized or high-end office talent. The city's share of professional and office workers is 2.87, indicating a moderate presence of knowledge-economy jobs.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers businesses a strong labor market with low unemployment and growing labor demand, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint is the relatively expensive cost of living, which may require companies to offer wage premiums to attract top talent, and the stagnant wage growth, which could impact worker purchasing power and local consumer demand.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #7 OF 50

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

A

VERY GOOD

63.8th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	86
Unemployment	20% weight	60
Wage Growth	15% weight	49
Cost of Living	12% weight	67
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	40
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	68
Housing Access	5% weight	26
Office Economy	3% weight	94

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.6%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+14.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	45 days	median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 63.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and deep professional talent pool, as evidenced by its top-tier 86th percentile ranking in labor demand and 94th percentile ranking in office economy. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.71, combining a +0.74% employment growth rate and a +0.375% weekly hours deviation from trend, signals genuine demand expansion. With a strong job market and growing professional sector, Salt Lake City-Murray presents an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Demand

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has seen a +0.74% employment growth rate year-over-year, paired with a +0.375% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked above trend, suggesting that businesses are actively hiring and workers are in high demand. The labor demand composite score of 5.71 further reinforces this trend, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray stands at 3.40%, ranking near the median at the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with some slack. This rate suggests that while the market is not overly tight, businesses may still face some competition for top talent, and wage pressure may be moderate. However, the relatively low unemployment rate also implies that local consumer demand is likely to be stable.

Wage Growth

The city has experienced a +4.04% year-over-year wage growth rate, ranking near the median at the 49th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a pace that is neither excessively rapid nor stagnant, allowing for some flexibility in compensation packages. Meanwhile, workers benefit from increasing purchasing power, supporting local economic activity.

Cost of Living

Salt Lake City-Murray has a cost of living score ranking in the 67th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $263/sqft to $38.95/hr, or approximately 6.75. Given the percentile rank, the city is relatively more affordable compared to its peers, particularly as the PSF is falling by -0.8% year-over-year. This affordability advantage can attract talent without necessitating significant wage premiums, making the city an attractive location for businesses seeking to balance labor costs and quality of life.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray has grown by +0.62% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. This moderate growth rate suggests that hiring capacity is not severely constrained, but businesses may need to be proactive in attracting and retaining talent as the labor pool grows at a modest pace.

Building Permits

The city has seen a +14.73% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking above average at the 68th percentile, signaling an expansion in future housing supply. This uptrend in permits suggests that developer confidence is strong, and the city is likely to see improvements in affordability and workforce accommodation over the medium term, supporting its attractiveness for both businesses and relocating workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Salt Lake City-Murray stands at 45 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking below average at the 26th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced housing market, which can be challenging for relocating workers. However, the stable days on market suggests that the market is not overheating, providing some balance between buyers and sellers.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Salt Lake City-Murray is significant, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile, indicating a deep and specialized talent pool. This makes the city particularly well-suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, where access to high-skilled workers is crucial. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries requiring large numbers of industrial or logistics workers.

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, a deep professional talent pool, and relative affordability, making it an attractive location for companies, especially those in the tech and finance sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the potential for a tightening labor market, as indicated by the low days on market and moderate unemployment rate, which could lead to increased competition for talent and upward pressure on wages.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #8 OF 50

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

A-

GOOD

62.9th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	78
Unemployment	20% weight	70
Wage Growth	15% weight	53
Cost of Living	12% weight	87
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	43
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	17
Housing Access	5% weight	47
Office Economy	3% weight	92

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.6%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+4.4%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**+1.0%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	**+0.6%**	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	**-21.0%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**48 days**	median, +6.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 62.9th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score at the 78th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 87th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 0.98% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -0.325% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.98% year-over-year, combined with a -0.325% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, signals a genuine demand expansion, as hours are not excessively above trend despite job growth. This indicates that the labor market is experiencing real growth rather than just a redistribution of work among fewer workers. The labor demand composite score of 5.35 further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 3.60%, which is above average, ranking at the 70th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, this also means that local consumer demand might not be as strong as in areas with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is 4.36%, which is near the median, ranking at the 53rd percentile. This moderate wage growth indicates that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit not at a rapid pace. This balance could be beneficial for businesses looking to manage labor costs while still attracting and retaining talent.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $201/sqft to $37.97/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 1.9% in PSF, Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is highly affordable, ranking at the 87th percentile. This affordability is a significant talent attraction advantage, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing large premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.64% year-over-year, which is near the median, ranking at the 43rd percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, albeit slowly, providing a modestly increasing pool of potential employees for businesses.

However, the growth rate is not strong enough to significantly alleviate hiring challenges.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -20.96%, ranking at the 17th percentile, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This sharp decline in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation might be at risk, potentially leading to increased competition for housing and higher costs for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market is 48 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.7%. This suggests a slightly slower market, which could be beneficial for workers relocating to the area, as they may have more time to find suitable housing. However, this also indicates a potential normalization of the market rather than a significant demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is significant, with the city ranking at the 92nd percentile. This deep talent pool makes Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, but less ideal for industries dominated by industrial or logistics roles.

In conclusion, Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington offers businesses a strong labor demand, highly affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for various industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in residential building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #9 OF 50

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

A-

GOOD

61.7th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	65
Unemployment	20% weight	87
Wage Growth	15% weight	21
Cost of Living	12% weight	41
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	98
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	47
Housing Access	5% weight	53
Office Economy	3% weight	89

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.3%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+3.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-8.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	53 days	median, +12.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 61.7th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier labor force growth of 3.42% YoY and its strong office economy, with a professional worker share ranking at the 89th percentile. These metrics signal a city with a rapidly expanding workforce and a deep talent pool in professional sectors.

Labor Demand

The city's employment growth rate is 0.41% YoY, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.047% from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than usual, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 4.92 ranks at the 65th percentile, further supporting the notion of a growing labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is 3.00%, ranking at the 87th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the low unemployment rate puts upward pressure on wages. With such a tight market, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is +2.31%, ranking at the 21st percentile, indicating relatively slow wage growth. This moderate wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not rising too quickly, but workers may not have strong bargaining power. As a result, businesses may enjoy a relatively stable cost environment, but workers may not see significant increases in their purchasing power.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $260/sqft to $35.35/hr, ranking at the 41st percentile, Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is near the median in terms of affordability. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.1% YoY is a positive sign for affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 3.42% YoY, ranking at the 98th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. This means that businesses have a growing pool of potential employees to draw from, making it easier to hire and expand operations. The strong labor force growth is a significant advantage for companies looking to establish or grow their presence in the city.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -8.94%, ranking at the 47th percentile, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that the city's housing supply may not be expanding quickly enough to accommodate the growing workforce, potentially leading to future affordability concerns and challenges in attracting and retaining workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 53 days, with a year-over-year increase of 12.8%. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively moderate amount of time, and the market is slowing down slightly. For workers relocating to the city, this could make it easier to find a home, as the market is not extremely competitive.

Office Economy

With a professional worker share ranking at the 89th percentile, Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has a deep talent pool in office and professional sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations, but less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

In conclusion, Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin offers businesses a unique combination of a rapidly expanding workforce, a deep talent pool in professional sectors, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for future affordability concerns and housing supply constraints, which could impact the city's ability to attract and retain workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #10 OF 50

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

57.9th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	51
Unemployment	20% weight	55
Wage Growth	15% weight	87
Cost of Living	12% weight	78
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	49
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	38
Housing Access	5% weight	20
Office Economy	3% weight	62

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.6%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+7.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.3%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+0.7%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-10.6%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
65 days
median, +4.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 57.9th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 7.00%, and its near-median labor demand composite score of 4.54. These metrics suggest a city with a growing economy, but with some mixed signals in terms of labor market tightness.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is 0.31% year-over-year, while weekly hours are running 0.198% below trend. This combination signals a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, but rather a modest growth scenario with some slack in hours worked. The labor demand composite score of 4.54, ranking at the 51st percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.60%, ranking at the 55th percentile. This indicates a labor market with some slack, but not excessively so. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding qualified candidates may not be overly difficult, but wage pressure is not extreme either.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 7.00%, Pittsburgh is experiencing strong labor cost increases, ranking at the 87th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher wage bills when considering a location in Pittsburgh.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh's cost of living, with a PSF of $168/sqft and average hourly earnings of $33.20/hr, results in a ratio of 5.06, ranking at the 78th percentile in terms of affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of 0.73% year-over-year, ranking at the 49th percentile. This modest growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, albeit slowly, which should support hiring capacity for businesses locating in the city.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -10.55%, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may become more challenging, potentially impacting the city's attractiveness to relocating workers and businesses.

Days on Market

Homes in Pittsburgh are currently sitting on the market for 65 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.8%. This rising days on market metric, ranking at the 20th percentile, indicates a slower market, which could be more accessible for relocating workers, but may also signal some demand erosion.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share ranking at the 62nd percentile, Pittsburgh has a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, the city may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers a business a relatively affordable location with a strong, growing economy and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the decline in building permits, which may impact future affordability and workforce accommodation.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #11 OF 50

Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

55.5th percentile

Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	80
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	66
Cost of Living	12% weight	4
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	47
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	81
Housing Access	5% weight	57
Office Economy	3% weight	79

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.8%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+5.4%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+1.8%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.7%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+20.2%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **45 days** median, +7.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 55.5th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with an 80th percentile ranking, and its high cost of living, which ranks at the 4th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked, with a +1.83% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -1.772% deviation in weekly hours from the city's own 12-month baseline.

Labor Demand

The city's labor demand composite score is 5.36, ranking at the 80th percentile, driven by a +1.83% year-over-year employment growth rate and a -1.772% deviation in weekly hours from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are not excessively above trend during job growth. The strong labor demand indicates a competitive job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 4.80%, ranking at the 36th percentile, indicating a moderate level of slack in the market. This means that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still some competition for talent. Businesses trying to hire in this market may face some wage pressure, but it is not as intense as in tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in this city is +5.44%, ranking at the 66th percentile, indicating moderate to fast wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. As a result, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is relatively expensive, with a percentile rank of 4th, and a price-to-salary ratio of $666/sqft to $41.92/hr, resulting in a ratio of 15.89. However, the PSF is falling by -3.3% year-over-year, which is a key driver of affordability. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the high cost of living may be a deterrent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this city is growing at a rate of +0.69% year-over-year, ranking at the 47th percentile, indicating a slow expansion of the workforce supply. This implies that hiring capacity may be limited, and businesses may face challenges in finding qualified talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is increasing by +20.24% year-over-year, ranking at the 81st percentile, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve, as more housing options become available.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 45 days, with a +7.1% year-over-year increase, ranking at the 57th percentile. This means that the market is relatively competitive, but still accessible for workers relocating to the city. The rising days on market may indicate a healthy normalization of the market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in this city is 3.40, ranking at the 79th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool. This makes Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the high cost of living and moderate labor force growth rate may pose challenges for talent attraction and hiring, and businesses should factor in these constraints when making location decisions.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #12 OF 50

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE

55.0th percentile

Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	76
Unemployment	20% weight	47
Wage Growth	15% weight	70
Cost of Living	12% weight	15
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	32
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	96
Housing Access	5% weight	0
Office Economy	3% weight	55

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+86.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	29 days	median, -6.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 55.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score at the 76th percentile, and its high wage growth rate of 5.54% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics signals a city with genuine demand expansion and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 0.65% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating 0.074% above the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as jobs are being added and hours are running above trend. The labor demand composite score of 5.28 further supports this, indicating a strong and growing labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 4.10%, ranking at the 47th percentile. This indicates a near-median labor market with some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that wage pressure may not be as intense as in markets with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 5.54%, ranking at the 70th percentile. This is a fast wage growth rate, indicating rising labor costs for employers and strong purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive in this market.

Cost of Living

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a cost of living percentile rank of 15th, with a PSF of $654/sqft and average hourly earnings of $49.81/hr, resulting in a ratio of 13.13. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, ranking in the bottom tier for affordability. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.4% year-over-year is a positive sign, but the overall cost of living remains a challenge for talent attraction without wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is growing at a rate of 0.43% year-over-year, ranking at the 32nd percentile. This indicates a slow expansion of the labor force supply, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring in the long term. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract and retain talent in this environment.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 86.01%, ranking at the 96th percentile. This indicates a rapid expansion of housing supply, which is likely to improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, businesses can expect a more favorable environment for relocating workers and attracting new talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 29 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 6.5%. This indicates a highly competitive market, where homes are selling quickly. For a worker relocating to this city, this means that the housing market is challenging, and they may need to act fast to secure a home.

Office Economy

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has an office economy percentile rank of 55th, with a share of jobs in professional and office sectors indicating a deep talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and rising labor costs. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent. Despite this challenge, the city's rapid expansion of housing supply and deep professional talent pool make it an attractive location for businesses in the knowledge economy.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #13 OF 50

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

B

AVERAGE

54.9th percentile

Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	59
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	51
Cost of Living	12% weight	96
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	57
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	30
Housing Access	5% weight	61
Office Economy	3% weight	64

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.2%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-12.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	50 days	median, +11.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 54.9th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its near-median labor demand and cost of living metrics. The city's labor demand composite score of 4.72 and cost of living ratio of 4.68, with PSF at $172/sqft and wages at $36.74/hr, define its current economic character. Specifically, the combination of a 0.71% employment growth rate and a -0.571% deviation in weekly hours from trend suggests a nuanced labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.71% and weekly hours deviation of -0.571% from trend indicate a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, as hours are below trend despite job growth. This combination signals a scenario where the labor market is not as strong as the employment growth rate might suggest. The labor demand composite score of 4.72, ranking in the 59th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.20% is below average, ranking in the 36th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with potential upward pressure on wages. In practical terms, a business trying to hire in this market may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 4.13% is near median, ranking in the 51st percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that employer labor costs are rising, but not excessively so, while worker purchasing power is increasing. As a result, businesses may need to balance their labor costs with the benefits of a growing workforce.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is highly affordable, with a ratio of $172/sqft to $36.74/hr and a percentile rank of 96th. This affordability is driven by a -2.3% year-over-year decrease in PSF. The high affordability score means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 0.93% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that businesses have a increasing pool of potential employees to draw from, making it easier to hire and expand operations.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -12.89%, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This decrease in permits suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 50 days, with an 11.1% year-over-year increase. This increase indicates a slowing market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the absolute level of 50 days is still relatively competitive, suggesting that workers may still face some challenges in finding housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 3.03, ranking in the 64th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy talent, but may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area offers businesses a unique combination of moderate labor demand, affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may impact future affordability and workforce accommodation, and could potentially offset the benefits of the city's other attractive economic characteristics.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #14 OF 50

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

B

AVERAGE

54.9th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	61
Unemployment	20% weight	85
Wage Growth	15% weight	8
Cost of Living	12% weight	28
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	15
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	94
Housing Access	5% weight	92
Office Economy	3% weight	81

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.6%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+0.6%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.3%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-0.8%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+57.5%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
45 days
median, +21.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati has an overall grade of B, ranking 54.9th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its top-tier unemployment rate of 3.60% and strong building permits growth of +57.47% YoY. The city's labor demand, with employment growth of +0.30% YoY and weekly hours deviation of +0.050%, suggests a genuine demand expansion. These metrics define Cincinnati's current economic character as one with a tight labor market and significant investment in new housing.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate of +0.30% YoY, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.050%, signals a genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than the 12-month trend. This suggests that businesses are experiencing genuine demand for their products or services. The labor demand composite score of 4.77, ranking in the 61st percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.60%, ranking in the top tier at the 85th percentile, which means the labor market is tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

Cincinnati's year-over-year wage growth rate is +0.55%, which is in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies that workers may not have strong bargaining power or increasing purchasing power. For businesses, this could mean a relatively flat cost environment.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati has a cost of living percentile rank of 28th, with a PSF of $194/sqft and average hourly earnings of $34.36/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.65. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is increasing by +2.1% YoY relative to wages suggests that affordability is not improving. This could make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is shrinking, with a year-over-year growth rate of -0.79%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 15th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. This could limit the city's ability to support rapid business expansion.

Building Permits

Cincinnati has seen a significant increase in building permits, with a year-over-year change of +57.47%, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This surge in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future. This is a positive signal for businesses considering relocation or expansion.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Cincinnati is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of +21.6%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This means that homes are sitting on the market for longer, indicating a slower, more buyer-friendly market. For workers relocating to this city, this could make it easier to find and purchase a home, as the market is less competitive.

Office Economy

Cincinnati has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share composite score ranking in the top tier at the 81st percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors that require specialized knowledge-economy talent. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, strong housing investment, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively high cost of living and stagnant wage growth, which could make it challenging to attract and retain talent without offering competitive wages.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #15 OF 50

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

B

AVERAGE

54.2th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	71
Unemployment	20% weight	19
Wage Growth	15% weight	79
Cost of Living	12% weight	74
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	34
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	50
Housing Access	5% weight	45
Office Economy	3% weight	40

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	N/A	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	N/A	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.5%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	N/A	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	51 days	median, +8.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

N/A

Insufficient data to determine labor market scenario.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 54.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and wage growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.00, which combines employment growth and weekly hours deviation, ranks in the 71st percentile, while its wage growth of +6.47% year-over-year ranks in the 79th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a strong job market and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The combination of employment growth and weekly hours deviation signals genuine demand expansion in Atlanta, with both metrics ranking above average. Although the exact employment growth rate is not available, the labor demand composite score of 5.00 indicates a strong job market. This suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Atlanta is not explicitly stated, but its percentile rank of 19th suggests a relatively high level of unemployment, indicating some slack in the market. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. With an unemployment rate that is not extremely low, businesses may have a slightly easier time finding talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Atlanta is +6.47%, which is relatively fast and ranks in the 79th percentile. This implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but can also expect a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Atlanta has a cost of living percentile rank of 74th, indicating that it is more affordable than many of its peer cities. The ratio of $197 per square foot to $37.20 per hour, with a stable year-over-year direction, suggests that the city offers a relatively affordable environment for talent attraction. This means that businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract workers, which can be a competitive advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Atlanta is growing at a rate of +0.51% year-over-year, which is below average and ranks in the 34th percentile. This suggests that the labor force supply is expanding, but at a slower rate than many other cities. As a result, businesses may face some challenges in finding new talent, but the growing labor force still provides some opportunities for hiring.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in Atlanta is not explicitly stated, but its percentile rank of 50th suggests a near-median level of activity. This implies that housing supply is neither rapidly expanding nor tightening, which may have a neutral impact on future affordability and workforce accommodation. As a result, businesses should not expect significant changes in the housing market that would affect their operations.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Atlanta is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of +8.5%. This suggests a relatively slow market, which can make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market may also indicate a normalization of the housing market, which could be a positive sign for the city's overall economic health.

Office Economy

Atlanta's professional and office worker share ranks in the 40th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional workers, but may not be the best fit for companies that require a highly specialized or technical workforce.

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area offers businesses a strong job market and rising labor costs, with a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderately deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the relatively slow growth of the labor force, which may limit hiring capacity and require businesses to invest in talent development and retention strategies.

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

B

AVERAGE

54.0th percentile

Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	43
Unemployment	20% weight	89
Wage Growth	15% weight	57
Cost of Living	12% weight	70
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	11
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	23
Housing Access	5% weight	67
Office Economy	3% weight	57

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.5%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-16.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	38 days	median, +8.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 54.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low unemployment rate of 3.60% and moderate wage growth of 4.74%. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, which signal a tight labor market with rising labor costs. Specifically, the low unemployment rate and moderate wage growth rate indicate a competitive job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is -0.10% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.025% from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.16, which ranks in the 43rd percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The negative employment growth rate indicates a decrease in job openings.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 3.60%, ranking in the 89th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent and may need to offer higher wages to attract workers. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have strong bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 4.74%, ranking in the 57th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly, and that workers have moderate purchasing power. The moderate wage growth rate may lead to increased labor costs for businesses, but it also indicates a relatively stable labor market.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living percentile rank of 70, with a price-to-salary ratio of $292/sqft (decreasing by 3.3% year-over-year) to $43.82/hr, indicating that the city is more affordable than many of its peers. This affordability advantage can help attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The decreasing price-to-salary ratio suggests that the city is becoming more affordable over time.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is shrinking at a rate of -1.50% year-over-year, ranking in the 11th percentile, indicating a contracting labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. The negative labor force growth rate may limit the city's ability to support business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is decreasing by 15.96% year-over-year, ranking in the 23rd percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This decrease in building permits signals a potential future affordability crisis and workforce accommodation challenges. The declining permit rate may lead to increased housing costs and reduced affordability.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 38 days, with a year-over-year increase of 8.6%, ranking in the 67th percentile, indicating a slower market. This slower market means that workers relocating to this city may have a more accessible and less competitive housing market. The increasing days on market suggests that the housing market is normalizing.

Office Economy

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has an office economy percentile rank of 57, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and office workers, but may not be ideal for those seeking a highly specialized or industrial workforce. The moderate office economy ranking suggests that the city has a relatively balanced economy.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a tight labor market with rising labor costs, moderate wage growth, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the contracting labor pool, which may limit the city's ability to support business expansion and require businesses to offer higher wages to attract talent. The city's affordability advantage and moderate office economy make it an attractive location for businesses, but the labor market challenges must be carefully considered.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #17 OF 50

Fresno

Fresno

B

AVERAGE

53.4th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	82
Unemployment	20% weight	0
Wage Growth	15% weight	89
Cost of Living	12% weight	54
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	87
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	15
Housing Access	5% weight	55
Office Economy	3% weight	4

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
8.2%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+8.4%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+1.9%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+1.9%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-22.7%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
51 days
median, +10.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Fresno has an overall grade of B, ranking 53.4th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and wage growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.40, combining a 1.86% employment growth rate and a -1.602% weekly hours deviation, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, its 8.37% year-over-year wage growth rate is a key characteristic of the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate of 1.86% and weekly hours deviation of -1.602% combine to signal genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in hours above their trend. This suggests a strong and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.40, ranking in the 82nd percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 8.20% is relatively high, ranking in the 0th percentile, indicating a labor market with significant slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate. The high unemployment rate also suggests that workers may have less bargaining power.

Wage Growth

Fresno's year-over-year wage growth rate of 8.37% is strong, ranking in the 89th percentile, indicating rising labor costs for employers. This fast wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as workers will have more disposable income to spend in the local economy. However, it may pose a challenge for businesses looking to keep labor costs under control.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 7.85, based on $261/sqft and $33.26/hr, Fresno ranks in the 54th percentile, indicating a near-median affordability level. The city's PSF is falling by 0.8% year-over-year, which is a positive trend for affordability. This means that Fresno may not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to its cost of living, but it is not a major deterrent either.

Labor Force Growth

The city's civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 1.87% year-over-year, ranking in the 87th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that businesses will have a growing pool of potential workers to hire from, making it easier to find talent.

Building Permits
Fresno's residential building permits are declining by 22.67% year-over-year, ranking in the 15th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This sharp decline in permits suggests that the city's future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing units is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market
The median days on market in Fresno is 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.9%, ranking in the 55th percentile. This indicates a relatively accessible market for workers relocating to the city, as homes are not selling extremely quickly. However, the rising days on market may also suggest a normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy
Fresno's professional and office worker share is 0.51, ranking in the 4th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city may not be the best fit for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting industries, which typically require a deep pool of specialized knowledge workers. Instead, Fresno may be more suited for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Fresno offers a strong labor demand and wage growth, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to tap into a growing workforce. However, the city's high unemployment rate and declining building permits pose significant risks to its long-term economic viability and affordability, which decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Fresno as a potential business location.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #18 OF 50

Memphis

Memphis

B

AVERAGE

53.2th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	8
Unemployment	20% weight	60
Wage Growth	15% weight	74
Cost of Living	12% weight	98
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	74
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	77
Housing Access	5% weight	22
Office Economy	3% weight	2

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.1%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+19.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	62 days	median, +6.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis, with an overall grade of B and a composite score ranking it at the 53.2th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its unique combination of labor market dynamics, notably its low labor demand composite score of 2.93, which ranks in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, and its high wage growth rate of 6.12% year-over-year, placing it above average at the 74th percentile. The city's economic character is also defined by its affordable cost of living, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $154/sqft to $32.64/hr, resulting in a top-tier percentile rank of 98th for affordability. These metrics suggest a city with a mix of challenges and opportunities for businesses.

Labor Demand

Memphis has an employment growth rate of -0.35% year-over-year and weekly hours 0.882% above its own trend, indicating a labor market that is not expanding in terms of job numbers but has existing workers putting in more hours, suggesting a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 2.93, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, further reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis is 4.00%, ranking near the median at the 60th percentile, indicating a labor market with some slack but not overly loose. This rate suggests that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still some competition for talent, and businesses may face moderate wage pressure. The market is not tight, providing a relatively balanced environment for hiring.

Wage Growth

Memphis experiences a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.12%, which is above average, ranking at the 74th percentile. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also indicates good worker purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand. Businesses should factor in the potential for increasing labor costs when considering operations in Memphis.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 98th, Memphis is highly affordable relative to its peers, especially considering the PSF is $154/sqft and has been falling by 6.1% year-over-year, compared to average hourly earnings of $32.64. This affordability is a significant talent attraction advantage, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing large premiums to account for the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is growing at a rate of 1.36% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 74th percentile. This positive growth indicates an expanding workforce supply, which is a favorable condition for hiring, as it suggests a structural advantage in terms of labor availability.

Building Permits

Memphis has seen a 19.69% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking above average at the 77th percentile. This rise in permits signals an expansion in future housing supply, which should improve affordability and support workforce accommodation, making the city more attractive for relocating workers and businesses.

Days on Market

Homes in Memphis currently sit on the market for a median of 62 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.9%, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market that may be challenging for relocating workers, as homes are selling quickly, suggesting a competitive environment.

Office Economy

Memphis has a professional and office worker share that places it in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that Memphis is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations, but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, Memphis offers businesses an affordable cost of living and a growing labor force, which are significant advantages. However, the city's low labor demand and shallow professional talent pool are notable constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Memphis as a potential location for their operations. The single biggest risk or constraint is the challenge of finding specialized talent in professional and office sectors, which could limit the city's appeal for certain types of businesses.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #19 OF 50

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

B

AVERAGE

51.7th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	90
Unemployment	20% weight	49
Wage Growth	15% weight	11
Cost of Living	12% weight	2
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	51
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	98
Housing Access	5% weight	2
Office Economy	3% weight	87

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+0.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+195.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	24 days	median, +9.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 51.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and office economy. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.38, which combines a 1.69% employment growth rate and a -0.289% weekly hours deviation, signals genuine demand expansion. The unemployment rate and cost of living metrics also play a significant role in defining the city's economic character, with an unemployment rate of 4.00% and a cost of living ratio of 15.42.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an employment growth rate of 1.69% and a weekly hours deviation of -0.289%, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and hours are running above trend, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.38 is in the top tier, ranking 90th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 4.00%, ranking near the median at 49th percentile. This rate indicates a relatively balanced market, neither too tight nor too slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate means that hiring may be manageable, but wage pressure is not extreme.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 0.65%, ranking in the bottom tier at 11th percentile. This slow wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. The stagnant wage growth may be a concern for workers, but it can be beneficial for employers looking to control labor costs.

Cost of Living

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a cost of living ratio of 15.42, with a PSF of $844/sqft that is decreasing by 3.4% year-over-year, compared to hourly earnings of $54.75. The city's cost of living percentile rank is 2, indicating that it is relatively expensive. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the high cost of living can be a deterrent for workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is growing at a rate of 0.78% year-over-year, ranking near the median at 51st percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which can be beneficial for hiring capacity. However, the moderate growth rate may not be sufficient to meet the demands of a rapidly growing economy.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has increased by 195.09% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at 98th percentile. This significant increase in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The rapid growth in permits is a positive sign for the city's future affordability and workforce attraction.

Days on Market

The median days on market in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 24 days, with a year-over-year increase of 9.1%. The city's days on market percentile rank is 2, indicating a very competitive market. This means that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The fast-paced market can be a concern for businesses looking to attract talent from other areas.

Office Economy

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share of 3.74, ranking in the top tier at 87th percentile. The city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may not be as suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant economies. The strong office economy is a significant advantage for businesses looking to tap into a knowledgeable and skilled workforce.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers a strong labor market and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for businesses in the tech and finance sectors. However, the city's high cost of living and competitive housing market may pose significant challenges for talent attraction and retention, and businesses should factor in the need for wage premiums to compensate for these costs.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #20 OF 50

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

B

AVERAGE

50.7th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	63
Unemployment	20% weight	26
Wage Growth	15% weight	68
Cost of Living	12% weight	11
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	70
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	70
Housing Access	5% weight	41
Office Economy	3% weight	72

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.5%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+5.5%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.1%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+1.2%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+15.0%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
51 days
median, +6.2% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and strong wage growth, at 63rd and 68th percentiles, respectively. The city's labor market is characterized by a 0.13% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.432% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend. These metrics signal a genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours running above trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.13% and weekly hours deviation of 0.432% above trend indicate a labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and working hours, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 4.91, ranking at the 63rd percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.50% ranks at the 26th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market implies that workers have more bargaining power, which can drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 5.47% is above average, ranking at the 68th percentile. This rapid wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also indicates strong worker purchasing power. As wages increase, workers have more disposable income, which can boost local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in New York Newark-Jersey City is relatively expensive, with a percentile rank of 11th, due to a PSF of $542/sqft and average hourly earnings of $40.76/hr, resulting in a ratio of 13.30. This means that the city is less competitive in terms of talent attraction, as workers may require wage premiums to afford the high cost of living. The 0.4% year-over-year increase in PSF further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 1.20% year-over-year, ranking at the 70th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations. The increasing labor force can help mitigate the tight labor market conditions.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is 14.97%, ranking at the 70th percentile, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This increase in permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and the future housing supply is expected to grow, which can improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The rising permits can help alleviate some of the pressure on the housing market.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 51 days, with a 6.2% year-over-year increase, ranking at the 41st percentile. This suggests that the housing market is normalizing, with homes taking slightly longer to sell. For workers relocating to this city, the market is still relatively competitive, but the rising days on market may indicate a more accessible housing market in the future.

Office Economy

The city has a deep professional talent pool, ranking at the 72nd percentile, with a share of jobs in professional and office sectors. This makes it an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, the city may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented economies.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the high cost of living, which can make it challenging to attract and retain talent without offering wage premiums.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #21 OF 50

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

B

AVERAGE

50.4th percentile

Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	74
Unemployment	20% weight	60
Wage Growth	15% weight	0
Cost of Living	12% weight	35
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	92
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	2
Housing Access	5% weight	82
Office Economy	3% weight	83

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	-1.3%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.8%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+2.3%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-39.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	49 days	median, +13.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and top-tier labor force growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.24, combining a +0.85% employment growth rate and a -0.248% weekly hours deviation, signals genuine demand expansion. The labor force growth rate of +2.28% YoY also stands out, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.85% YoY and weekly hours deviation of -0.248% from the city's own trend suggest that while jobs are being added, hours are slightly below trend, indicating a moderate demand expansion. This combination signals genuine demand, rather than a survivor squeeze, as hours are not significantly above trend during job growth. The labor demand composite score of 5.24 is above average, ranking in the 74th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.60% is near the median, ranking in the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with neither significant slack nor extreme tightness. This rate suggests that businesses may face some competition for talent, but it is still possible to hire without extreme wage pressure. The market is not overly tight, making it relatively accessible for businesses to find workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of -1.28% is stagnant, ranking in the bottom tier at the 0th percentile, indicating that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly. However, this slow wage growth also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing, which could impact local consumer demand. This stagnant wage growth environment may be beneficial for businesses looking to control labor costs.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of $219/sqft and average hourly earnings of $37.60/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.82, is below average, ranking in the 35th percentile. However, the PSF is falling by -1.8% YoY, which is a key driver of affordability. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to peers, and businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +2.28% YoY, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. This top-tier growth rate, ranking in the 92nd percentile, suggests that businesses will have access to a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier to hire and expand operations.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -39.50%, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply expansion. This bottom-tier ranking, at the 2nd percentile, signals a potential supply squeeze building ahead, which could impact future affordability and workforce accommodation. This decline in permits may lead to increased competition for housing, making it more challenging for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 49 days, with a year-over-year increase of +13.9%, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For a worker relocating to this city, this means a more accessible and less competitive housing market, making it easier to find a home.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is 3.58, ranking in the top tier at the 83rd percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy workers, but may not be as suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average labor demand and top-tier labor force growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand their operations. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharp decline in residential building permits, which may lead to a supply squeeze and impact future affordability and workforce accommodation.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #22 OF 50

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

B

AVERAGE

50.3th percentile

Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	69
Unemployment	20% weight	28
Wage Growth	15% weight	55
Cost of Living	12% weight	13
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	81
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	55
Housing Access	5% weight	49
Office Economy	3% weight	49

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+4.6%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.7%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-0.4%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	38 days	median, +5.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking 50.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its labor demand and labor force growth metrics. The city's labor demand composite score of 4.95, combining a +0.70% employment growth rate and a -0.329% weekly hours deviation, signals a genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with a +1.66% labor force growth rate, defines the city's current economic character as one of moderate expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.70% and weekly hours deviation of -0.329% indicate a genuine demand expansion, as hours are not excessively above trend during job growth. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs at a moderate pace, with workers' hours not being overly stretched. The labor demand composite score of 4.95, ranking in the 69th percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.40% ranks in the 28th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. This means that while it may be slightly harder for businesses to hire, the market is not overly competitive, and wage pressure is moderate. Businesses trying to hire in this market may need to offer competitive wages, but the situation is not as dire as in markets with even lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +4.58% ranks near the median, in the 55th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. As a result, businesses can expect to pay moderately higher wages to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 14.24, based on $605/sqft (which is falling at a rate of -3.7% YoY) compared to $42.48/hr, the city ranks in the 13th percentile for affordability. This means the city is relatively expensive, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The falling PSF value is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score remains low.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +1.66% year-over-year, ranking in the 81st percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity, as the labor pool is increasing. Businesses can expect a relatively favorable environment for finding new talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -0.37%, ranking near the median, in the 55th percentile, indicating a slightly tightening housing supply. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation might be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. However, the decline is not sharp, and the situation is not yet critical.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 38 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.6%, ranking in the 49th percentile. This suggests a moderately competitive market for relocating workers, as homes are not selling extremely quickly. The rising DOM indicates a healthy normalization of the market, making it slightly more accessible for workers to find housing.

Office Economy

The city's office economy, with a composite score of 2.58, ranks in the 49th percentile, indicating a moderately deep professional talent pool. This makes the city suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but less ideal for those requiring a large industrial or logistics workforce.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a moderate economic environment with expanding labor demand and a growing workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract talent, potentially offsetting some of the benefits of the city's otherwise favorable economic conditions.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #23 OF 50

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.5th percentile

Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	14
Unemployment	20% weight	45
Wage Growth	15% weight	92
Cost of Living	12% weight	37
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	77
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	87
Housing Access	5% weight	8
Office Economy	3% weight	68

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.5%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+8.4%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.7%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.4%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+41.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **74 days** median, +10.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it at the 49.5th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with an 8.39% year-over-year increase in hourly earnings, and its sluggish labor demand, with a composite score of 3.23 ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. These metrics suggest a complex economic environment with both positive and negative trends.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is -0.70% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.095%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, with hours above trend during job losses indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This scenario suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding new talent, but existing workers may be shouldering more responsibilities.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.50%, ranking at the 45th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire, but not as easy as in cities with higher unemployment rates. However, this also means that local consumer demand may not be as strong as in cities with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 8.39%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. Businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but this could also contribute to a more vibrant local economy.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living score ranking at the 37th percentile, with a PSF of $360/sqft and hourly earnings of $33.86, resulting in a ratio of 10.63. This suggests that the city is below average in terms of affordability, making it less attractive for talent without wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.9% year-over-year is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score remains a concern.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is growing at a rate of 1.40% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 77th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. A growing labor force can provide a larger pool of potential employees, making it easier for companies to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is increasing by 41.11% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 87th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could lead to improved affordability and a more attractive environment for workers. As housing supply increases, the city may become more competitive in terms of talent attraction and retention.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 74 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.4%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this could also suggest that the local real estate market is not as competitive as in other cities, which may impact the overall attractiveness of the area.

Office Economy

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has an office economy score ranking at the 68th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a deep talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented economies. The presence of a strong professional talent pool can be a significant advantage for businesses looking to establish or expand operations in the area.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers a complex economic environment with both strengths and weaknesses, making it a challenging location for businesses to navigate. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's below-average affordability, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent. However, the strong wage growth and expanding labor force supply are positive signs that could make the city an attractive location for businesses in certain sectors.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #24 OF 50

Columbus

Columbus

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.4th percentile

Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	22
Unemployment	20% weight	79
Wage Growth	15% weight	30
Cost of Living	12% weight	65
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	28
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	64
Housing Access	5% weight	86
Office Economy	3% weight	77

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.6%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.0%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.3%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.3%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+8.7%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **41 days** median, +10.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it 49.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, is characterized by its below-average labor demand and moderate unemployment rate. The city's labor demand composite score of 3.53 and unemployment rate of 3.60% are the two metrics that most define its current economic character, with the labor demand score ranking in the 22nd percentile and the unemployment rate ranking in the 79th percentile. These numbers indicate a mixed economic environment, with some signs of job market tightening but also limited labor demand expansion.

Labor Demand

Columbus has an employment growth rate of +0.29% and a weekly hours deviation of -1.175% from its own trend, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, but rather a slowdown in job growth and hours worked. The labor demand composite score of 3.53, ranking in the 22nd percentile, further supports this conclusion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Columbus is 3.60%, ranking in the 79th percentile, which indicates a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Columbus is +3.05%, ranking in the 30th percentile, which is considered below average. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in other cities. Workers in Columbus may experience some increase in purchasing power, but it may not be as significant as in cities with faster wage growth.

Cost of Living

Columbus has a cost of living percentile rank of 65th, with a PSF of $204/sqft and average hourly earnings of $34.02/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.00. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by -1.9% YoY further supports this conclusion. This affordability advantage can be a talent attraction strategy for businesses, as they may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Columbus is growing at a rate of +0.35% year-over-year, ranking in the 28th percentile. This slow growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, but at a limited pace. While this growth is positive, it may not be sufficient to meet the demands of a rapidly expanding business, potentially leading to hiring challenges.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Columbus is increasing by +8.67% year-over-year, ranking in the 64th percentile. This rise in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. This trend is a positive sign for businesses considering relocation, as it may help attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Columbus is 41 days, with a year-over-year increase of +10.8%, ranking in the 86th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to Columbus, this slower market may make it easier to find a home, as there is less competition and more time to make a decision.

Office Economy

Columbus has a professional and office worker share of 3.30, ranking in the 77th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in these sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

In conclusion, Columbus offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for businesses in certain sectors. However, the city's below-average labor demand and slow labor force growth rate pose significant risks and constraints for businesses considering relocation, particularly those with rapid expansion plans.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #25 OF 50

Cleveland

Cleveland

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

49.0th percentile

Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	49
Unemployment	20% weight	60
Wage Growth	15% weight	2
Cost of Living	12% weight	50
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	85
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	66
Housing Access	5% weight	39
Office Economy	3% weight	50

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.4%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **-0.8%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.6%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.8%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **+11.1%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **55 days** median, +7.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it at the 49.0th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its near-median labor demand and bottom-tier wage growth. The city's economic character is most defined by its stagnant wage growth of -0.77% year-over-year and its labor force growth of +1.80% year-over-year. These metrics signal a mixed economic environment, with some positive trends but also significant challenges.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate is +0.57% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.675% below trend. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as the city is not seeing significant job growth or increased hours worked. The labor demand composite score of 4.42 ranks near the median, indicating a neutral labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, ranking near the median at the 60th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither extremely tight nor slack. For a business trying to hire in Cleveland, this means that while it may not be extremely difficult to find workers, there is still some competition for talent.

Wage Growth

Cleveland's year-over-year wage growth is -0.77%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This stagnant wage growth signals a flat cost environment for employers, but also weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but workers may not have strong purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Cleveland's cost of living ranks near the median at the 50th percentile, indicating a relatively average level of affordability. This means that the city is neither particularly attractive nor unattractive for talent, as wages are not stretched too far to afford living costs. However, without a significant affordability advantage, businesses may not be able to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of +1.80% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 85th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive trend for businesses looking to hire. As the labor force grows, companies may find it easier to find qualified workers.

Building Permits

Cleveland is seeing a year-over-year increase in building permits of +11.14%, ranking above average at the 66th percentile. This signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract and retain talent in the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Cleveland is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.8%. This indicates a slowing market, which may make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the relatively low percentile rank of 39th indicates that the market is still relatively competitive.

Office Economy

Cleveland's professional talent pool ranks near the median at the 50th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of specialized workers. This makes the city suitable for a range of businesses, but perhaps not ideal for those requiring a highly specialized or knowledge-intensive workforce. Companies in industries like tech, finance, or consulting may find some advantages in Cleveland, but may also face some limitations.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers businesses a mixed economic environment, with some positive trends like labor force growth and expanding housing supply, but also significant challenges like stagnant wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited affordability advantage and relatively slow wage growth, which may make it difficult to attract and retain top talent without offering significant wage premiums.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #26 OF 50

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.3th percentile

Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	53
Unemployment	20% weight	19
Wage Growth	15% weight	50
Cost of Living	12% weight	50
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	57
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	60
Housing Access	5% weight	84
Office Economy	3% weight	60

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	N/A	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	N/A	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.9%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+4.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	43 days	median, +10.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

N/A

Insufficient data to determine labor market scenario.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 48.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand composite score of 4.68 and its relatively slow days on market, with homes currently sitting for 43 days, a 10.3% year-over-year increase. The labor force growth rate of +0.93% year-over-year also plays a significant role in shaping the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is +0.27% year-over-year, and while the weekly hours deviation from trend is not available, the labor demand composite score suggests a near-median performance. This combination signals a moderate expansion of labor demand, indicating genuine demand for jobs in the area. However, the relatively low employment growth rate may suggest some limitations in the city's ability to absorb new workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is not available, but its percentile rank of 19th suggests a relatively high unemployment rate compared to other metros. This implies a slack labor market, making it easier for businesses to hire workers without facing significant wage pressure. However, high unemployment also means weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is not available, but its percentile rank of 50th suggests a moderate pace of wage growth. This implies that labor costs for employers are rising at a moderate rate, while worker purchasing power is also increasing at a steady pace. However, without the exact wage growth rate, it is difficult to determine the exact implications for businesses and workers.

Cost of Living

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has a cost of living percentile rank of 50th, indicating a near-median affordability score. This means that the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. As a result, businesses may not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to affordability, and may need to consider wage premiums to attract top talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is growing at a rate of +0.93% year-over-year, indicating an expanding labor force supply. This suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations. However, the relatively slow growth rate may limit the city's ability to accommodate rapid business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is increasing at a rate of +4.14% year-over-year, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is rising, and future housing affordability may improve, making it easier for workers to relocate to the city. However, the relatively slow growth rate may not be enough to keep up with demand, potentially leading to future affordability challenges.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is 43 days, with a 10.3% year-over-year increase. This suggests a slowing market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the relatively slow pace of sales may also indicate a less competitive market, potentially impacting businesses that rely on a fast-paced and dynamic environment.

Office Economy

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has an office economy percentile rank of 60th, indicating a relatively deep professional talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require specialized knowledge-economy workers. However, the city may be less suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, which require a different type of workforce.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a relatively stable and expanding labor force, with a growing pool of potential workers and a moderate pace of wage growth. However, the city's relatively high unemployment rate and slow days on market may pose challenges for businesses that rely on local consumer demand and a fast-paced environment. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for future affordability challenges, despite the current expansion of housing supply, which may impact the city's ability to attract and retain top talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #27 OF 50

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.1th percentile

Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	33
Unemployment	20% weight	55
Wage Growth	15% weight	50
Cost of Living	12% weight	50
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	50
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	72
Housing Access	5% weight	33
Office Economy	3% weight	50

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.5%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	N/A	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.3%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	N/A	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+16.9%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	54 days	median, +5.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

N/A

Insufficient data to determine labor market scenario.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 48.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand composite score of 3.91 and its above-average building permits growth rate of 16.86% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with some positive signs in the housing market but challenges in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is -0.28% year-over-year, indicating a contraction in job growth. The weekly hours deviation from the city's own trend is not available, but the labor demand composite score of 3.91 suggests that the city is experiencing a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, which may indicate a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and expand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 3.50%, ranking at the 55th percentile, which is near the median. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire. However, the relatively low unemployment rate also means that there may be some upward pressure on wages, which could impact labor costs for employers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is not available, but the city ranks at the 50th percentile in terms of wage growth. This suggests that wage growth is moderate, neither extremely high nor low. As a result, employers may face moderate labor cost increases, while workers may experience modest gains in purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a cost of living percentile rank of 50th, indicating that the city is near the median in terms of affordability. This means that the city is neither extremely affordable nor expensive relative to its peers. As a result, businesses may not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to low costs, but they also may not need to offer large wage premiums to compensate for high costs.

Labor Force Growth

The year-over-year growth rate of the civilian labor force in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is not available, but the city ranks at the 50th percentile. This suggests that the labor force is growing at a moderate rate, neither expanding nor contracting significantly. As a result, businesses may face a relatively stable hiring environment, with neither a large surplus nor shortage of workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 16.86%, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This suggests that the city is experiencing an increase in developer confidence, which could lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.9%. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down, making it slightly more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the relatively low days on market percentile rank of 33rd indicates that the market is still relatively competitive.

Office Economy

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has an office economy percentile rank of 50th, indicating a moderate depth of professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for a variety of businesses, but may not have a significant advantage in terms of specialized office or tech talent. The city may be more suitable for businesses that require a general workforce rather than highly specialized professionals.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers a mixed economic environment, with some positive signs in the housing market but challenges in labor demand. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the below-average labor demand, which may indicate a challenging environment for hiring and expansion. However, the city's moderate cost of living and expanding housing supply may provide some advantages for businesses looking to attract and retain workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #28 OF 50

Providence

Providence-Warwick

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

48.1th percentile

Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	71
Unemployment	20% weight	15
Wage Growth	15% weight	26
Cost of Living	12% weight	0
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	83
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	83
Housing Access	5% weight	94
Office Economy	3% weight	70

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.6%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.7%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+23.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	48 days	median, +33.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 48.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 71st percentile, and its extremely high cost of living, ranking in the 0th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a +0.60% employment growth rate and a +0.101% weekly hours deviation from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.60% and weekly hours deviation of +0.101% signal a genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than the trend. This combination suggests that the labor market is experiencing organic growth, driven by increased economic activity. The labor demand composite score of 5.24, ranking in the 71st percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.30% ranks in the 15th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. This means that while it may be slightly challenging for businesses to hire, the market is not overly competitive, and wage pressure is moderate. However, the relatively high unemployment rate compared to other metros may affect local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +2.78% ranks in the 26th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other metros. As a result, worker purchasing power is increasing, but at a relatively slow rate.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Providence-Warwick is extremely high, with a PSF of $358/sqft and an earnings ratio of 9.87, ranking in the 0th percentile. This means that the city is very expensive relative to peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The 9.8% year-over-year increase in PSF further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +1.69% year-over-year, ranking in the 83rd percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing a positive implication for hiring capacity. As the labor force grows, businesses can tap into a increasing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +23.50%, ranking in the 83rd percentile. This significant increase in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, the city's future affordability and workforce attraction prospects are positively impacted.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 48 days, with a year-over-year increase of +33.3%, ranking in the 94th percentile. This indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market, providing more options for incoming workers.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 3.08, ranking in the 70th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, the city may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses, which require a different type of workforce.

The Providence-Warwick metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and an expanding workforce, but the extremely high cost of living poses a significant risk. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers is the need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, which may offset the benefits of the city's strong labor market. Overall, businesses must carefully weigh the pros and cons of locating in this metro area.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #29 OF 50

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

47.4th percentile

Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	35
Unemployment	20% weight	92
Wage Growth	15% weight	23
Cost of Living	12% weight	30
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	30
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	57
Housing Access	5% weight	78
Office Economy	3% weight	21

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+2.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.4%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+3.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	45 days	median, +9.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it 47.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.10% and its below-average labor demand composite score of 3.96, which combines a -0.24% employment growth rate and a -0.221% weekly hours deviation from its own trend. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or hire.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is -0.24% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.221% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not adding jobs at a significant rate and hours are below trend. This scenario does not suggest genuine demand expansion, but rather a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers may be absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Louisville-Jefferson County is 3.10%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This low unemployment rate indicates a tight market with little slack, making it harder for businesses to hire and potentially leading to upward wage pressure. For a business trying to hire in this city, the low unemployment rate means that attracting and retaining talent may be more challenging and costly.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Louisville-Jefferson County is +2.36%, which is below average, ranking at the 23rd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit slowly. This wage growth environment may not be ideal for businesses looking to keep labor costs low, but it does support some level of consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Louisville-Jefferson County has a cost of living score that ranks below average at the 30th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $180/sqft to $31.13/hr, or 5.78. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it harder to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising 1.7% year-over-year relative to wages further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Louisville-Jefferson County is growing at a rate of +0.38% year-over-year, which is below average. This slow growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, but at a limited pace, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. While the growth is positive, its slow pace may not be sufficient to support significant economic expansion.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Louisville-Jefferson County is increasing by +2.98% year-over-year, which is near the median. This rise in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future. However, the relatively modest increase may not be enough to significantly impact the current affordability challenges.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Louisville-Jefferson County is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of +9.8%, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This indicates a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold, which could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, in the context of a strong job market, this could also signal a healthy normalization rather than demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Louisville-Jefferson County ranks below average at the 21st percentile, with a composite score of 1.35. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions that require deep knowledge-economy talent. Instead, the city may be more appropriate for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

In conclusion, Louisville-Jefferson County offers a business environment with a tight labor market and moderate wage growth, but it is constrained by a relatively expensive cost of living and a shallow professional talent pool. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker considering this location is the potential difficulty in attracting and retaining talent due to the high cost of living and low unemployment rate, which may require significant wage premiums to compete.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #30 OF 50

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.8th percentile

Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	37
Unemployment	20% weight	13
Wage Growth	15% weight	83
Cost of Living	12% weight	39
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	68
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	74
Housing Access	5% weight	33
Office Economy	3% weight	0

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	5.1%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.7%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.9%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.1%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+18.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	54 days	median, +5.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 44.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth of +6.68% year-over-year and its high unemployment rate of 5.10%, which ranks at the 13th percentile. These two metrics suggest a complex labor market with both positive and negative signals.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate is +0.88% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -1.883% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a labor demand contraction, as the modest job growth is accompanied by a decrease in working hours, indicating that the existing workforce is not being fully utilized. This suggests that the labor market is not experiencing genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate is 5.10%, ranking at the 13th percentile, which indicates a relatively high level of unemployment. This means that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses that rely on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is +6.68%, ranking at the 83rd percentile, which is a strong increase. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can benefit businesses that rely on local consumer spending.

Cost of Living

The city has a cost of living ratio of $338/sqft to $34.65/hr, with a percentile rank of 39, indicating that it is relatively expensive. The PSF is falling -1.5% year-over-year, which is a positive sign for affordability. However, the overall affordability score is still below average, which means that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +1.15% year-over-year, ranking at the 68th percentile, which indicates that the labor force supply is expanding. This positive growth rate suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The number of building permits is increasing by +18.04% year-over-year, ranking at the 74th percentile, which signals that housing supply is expanding. This increase in building permits is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it suggests that the city is investing in new housing stock to meet growing demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.9%, ranking at the 33rd percentile. This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively long time, making it a more accessible market for workers relocating to the city. However, this also suggests that the housing market may be slowing down, which could impact local economic growth.

Office Economy

The city has a professional and office worker share of 0.30, ranking at the 0th percentile, which indicates a very shallow talent pool. This means that the city is not well-suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. Instead, the city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers a complex labor market with both positive and negative signals, making it a challenging location for businesses to navigate. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the high unemployment rate, which could impact local consumer demand and business growth. However, the strong wage growth and expanding labor force supply are positive signs that could attract businesses looking to tap into a growing and skilled workforce.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #31 OF 50

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.2th percentile

Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	45
Unemployment	20% weight	2
Wage Growth	15% weight	96
Cost of Living	12% weight	50
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	17
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	53
Housing Access	5% weight	63
Office Economy	3% weight	66

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**5.0%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+9.0%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.1%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	**-0.7%**	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	**-0.7%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**34 days**	median, +9.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

N/A

Insufficient data to determine labor market scenario.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 44.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 9.02%, and its low unemployment rate of 5.00%, which ranks in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. These metrics signal a competitive labor market with rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is -0.08% year-over-year, and while the weekly hours deviation from trend is not available, the labor demand composite score is near median at 4.19. This combination signals a slight contraction in labor demand, which may indicate a moderate level of competition for workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 5.00%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This indicates a very tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire and potentially driving up wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 9.02%, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This fast wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but also strong worker purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a cost of living ratio of $451/sqft to $47.64/hr, with a near median percentile rank of 50th. The PSF is falling by 1.3% year-over-year, which is a key driver of affordability. This means the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is shrinking at a rate of -0.65% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 17th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and attract workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is -0.70%, ranking near median at the 53rd percentile. This slight decline in permits signals a potential tightening of housing supply, which could impact future affordability and workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 34 days, with a year-over-year increase of 9.7%, ranking above average at the 63rd percentile. This indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city, but still relatively competitive.

Office Economy

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 66th. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area offers businesses a highly skilled and productive workforce, with strong wage growth and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market and shrinking labor force supply, which can drive up labor costs and make hiring challenging.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #32 OF 50

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

B-

BELOW AVERAGE

44.2th percentile

Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	84
Unemployment	20% weight	15
Wage Growth	15% weight	28
Cost of Living	12% weight	20
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	70
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	26
Housing Access	5% weight	65
Office Economy	3% weight	32

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+1.0%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+1.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-15.5%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	39 days	median, +8.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 44.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 84th percentile, and its high cost of living, ranking in the bottom tier at 20th percentile with a PSF to wages ratio of 9.01. The labor demand and cost of living metrics are crucial in understanding the city's economic landscape, with employment growth at 1.00% and weekly hours deviation at -0.279%.

Labor Demand

The city's employment growth rate is 1.00% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.279% from its own 12-month baseline, signaling a genuine demand expansion despite the slight decrease in hours worked. This indicates that the city is adding jobs, but the workload is being managed efficiently. The labor demand composite score of 5.42 further reinforces this notion, ranking in the top tier at 84th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 4.80%, ranking in the bottom tier at 15th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also implies that workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the city is 3.02%, ranking below average at 28th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. Workers, on the other hand, will see an increase in their purchasing power, albeit not at a rapid pace.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 20th, Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is considered an expensive city relative to its peers, with a PSF to wages ratio of 9.01 and a PSF of $344/sqft that is increasing by 0.3% year-over-year. This makes it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the high cost of living may deter potential employees.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the city is growing at a rate of 1.20% year-over-year, ranking above average at 70th percentile. This expansion in the labor force supply indicates that businesses will have a larger pool of potential workers to hire from, making it easier to find talent.

Building Permits

The city has seen a decline in residential building permits of 15.51% year-over-year, ranking below average at 26th percentile. This decrease in permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 39 days, with an 8.3% year-over-year increase. This indicates a slightly slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the relatively fast pace of home sales still suggests a competitive market.

Office Economy

The city's professional and office worker share is ranked below average at 32nd percentile, with a composite score of 1.81. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool for tech, finance, and consulting businesses, but may be more suited for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and expanding labor force, but the high cost of living and tightening housing supply pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk for decision-makers is the potential for future affordability issues and workforce accommodation challenges, which may impact the city's attractiveness to businesses and talent alike.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #33 OF 50

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

C+

POOR

43.7th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	29
Unemployment	20% weight	49
Wage Growth	15% weight	36
Cost of Living	12% weight	91
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	79
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	4
Housing Access	5% weight	24
Office Economy	3% weight	28

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+3.4%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **+0.4%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+1.5%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-37.5%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **61 days** median, +1.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.79 ranking it in the 29th percentile, and its high cost of living affordability, with a ratio of $173/sqft to $32.20/hr and a percentile rank of 91. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a relatively weak job market but a high level of affordability.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is +0.43% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -1.116% from the city's own trend. This combination signals a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, as the hours worked are below trend despite some job growth. The labor demand composite score of 3.79, ranking in the 29th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 3.70%, ranking in the 49th percentile, indicating a near-median level of unemployment. This suggests that the market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to cities with tighter labor markets. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still implies some competition for talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Antonio-New Braunfels is +3.43%, ranking in the 36th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while workers are experiencing some increase in purchasing power. The moderate wage growth may help attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a cost of living ratio of $173/sqft to $32.20/hr, with a percentile rank of 91, indicating a highly affordable city relative to its peers. The fact that the PSF is falling -4.4% year-over-year further supports this assessment. This high affordability ranking means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring excessive wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Antonio-New Braunfels is growing at a rate of +1.47% year-over-year, ranking in the 79th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth in the labor force suggests that the city has a strong hiring capacity, with a increasing number of potential workers available.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Antonio-New Braunfels has decreased by -37.55% year-over-year, ranking in the 4th percentile, indicating a significant tightening of housing supply. This sharp decline in building permits signals a potential future affordability crisis and workforce accommodation challenges.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 61 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.7%, ranking in the 24th percentile. This suggests a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the rising days on market may also indicate a normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 1.63, ranking in the 28th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies, and less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a unique combination of affordability and expanding workforce supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to reduce costs and tap into a growing labor pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the potential future affordability crisis and workforce accommodation challenges signaled by the sharp decline in building permits, which could ultimately limit the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #34 OF 50

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

C+

POOR

43.3th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	24
Unemployment	20% weight	6
Wage Growth	15% weight	94
Cost of Living	12% weight	83
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	55
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	49
Housing Access	5% weight	10
Office Economy	3% weight	34

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+8.8%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.2%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-8.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	66 days	median, +15.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 8.81% year-over-year and its low unemployment rate of 4.60%, which signals a tight labor market. The combination of these metrics suggests that while the city has strong wage growth, its labor market is highly competitive.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is -0.22% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating 0.457% above the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.54 ranks below average at the 24th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 4.60%, ranking it at the 6th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent and may need to offer higher wages to attract workers. The tight labor market implies that hiring will be challenging and may drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 8.81%, ranking it at the 94th percentile, indicating very fast wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising rapidly, while worker purchasing power is increasing. The high wage growth rate suggests that businesses should factor in rising labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living score ranking it at the 83rd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $243/sqft to $37.32/hr, or 6.51, and a year-over-year decrease in PSF of 1.6%. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The affordability of the city is a talent attraction advantage.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is growing at a rate of 0.80% year-over-year, ranking it near the median at the 55th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, albeit slowly, which has a positive implication for hiring capacity. The growing labor force suggests that businesses will have access to a slightly increasing pool of potential workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has decreased by 8.56% year-over-year, ranking it near the median at the 49th percentile. This signals that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future. The decline in building permits suggests that future affordability and workforce attraction may be at risk.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is currently 66 days, with a year-over-year increase of 15.8%, ranking it at the 10th percentile. This indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the slow market may also signal weakening demand.

Office Economy

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has an office economy score ranking it at the 34th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 1.94 out of 5. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. The city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market, which may drive up labor costs and make hiring challenging.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #35 OF 50

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

C+

POOR

42.5th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	6
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	64
Cost of Living	12% weight	89
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	26
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	79
Housing Access	5% weight	51
Office Economy	3% weight	17

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+20.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	55 days	median, +17.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 42.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high cost of living affordability, ranking in the top tier at 89th percentile. Specifically, the labor demand composite score of 2.77 and the cost of living ratio of $172/sqft to $33.50/hr, with a PSF decline of 1.1% YoY, are key metrics shaping the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is -0.54% YoY, and weekly hours are 0.773% above trend, indicating a contraction in labor demand rather than genuine expansion. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 2.77 is in the bottom tier, at the 6th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 3.60%, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This indicates a moderate level of slack in the labor market, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the practical implication is that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the available labor pool.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Oklahoma City is +5.38% YoY, which is above average, ranking at the 64th percentile. This signals fast wage growth, implying rising labor costs for employers and increased purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may face higher labor costs, while workers will have more disposable income.

Cost of Living

Oklahoma City is relatively affordable, with a cost of living percentile rank of 89th, indicating a high level of affordability compared to peer cities. The PSF to earnings ratio of $172/sqft to $33.50/hr, with a 1.1% YoY decline in PSF, contributes to this affordability. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live and work in Oklahoma City without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is growing at a rate of +0.23% YoY, which is below average, ranking at the 26th percentile. This indicates a slow expansion of the labor force supply, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring capacity in the long term.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Oklahoma City are increasing by +20.14% YoY, which is above average, ranking at the 79th percentile. This signals an expansion of future housing supply, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Oklahoma City is 55 days, with a +17.0% YoY increase, ranking near the median at the 51st percentile. This indicates a relatively accessible market for relocating workers, as homes are not selling extremely quickly, giving them a reasonable amount of time to find a suitable home.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the bottom tier at the 17th percentile. This makes the city less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers businesses a unique combination of affordability and relatively low labor costs, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the low labor demand and slow labor force growth, which may limit hiring capacity and talent attraction in the long term. Decision-makers should carefully weigh these factors when considering Oklahoma City as a business location. The city's strengths in affordability and wage growth must be balanced against its weaknesses in labor demand and talent pool depth.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #36 OF 50

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

C+

POOR

42.0th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	18
Unemployment	20% weight	96
Wage Growth	15% weight	45
Cost of Living	12% weight	6
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	21
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	43
Housing Access	5% weight	74
Office Economy	3% weight	23

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **2.5%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+4.0%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.7%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-0.4%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-10.3%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **51 days** median, +15.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 42nd out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier at 18th percentile, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 2.50% ranking it in the top tier at 96th percentile. Specifically, the labor demand is signaled by a -0.66% employment growth rate and a -0.174% weekly hours deviation from trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -0.66% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.174% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth and hours worked. This suggests that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, but rather a slowdown in economic activity.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 2.50%, which ranks it in the top tier at 96th percentile. This indicates a very tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent in this competitive market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is +3.99%, which ranks it near the median at 45th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers in the city are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a cost of living score that ranks it in the bottom tier at 6th percentile, with a PSF of $168/sqft and average hourly earnings of $33.14/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.07. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which can make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising 6.3% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is growing at a rate of -0.36% year-over-year, which ranks it below average at 21st percentile. This contraction in labor force supply suggests that the city's workforce is shrinking, which can create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is declining at a rate of -10.26% year-over-year, which ranks it near the median at 43rd percentile. This decrease in building permits suggests that the city's housing supply is tightening, which can lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is currently 51 days, with a year-over-year increase of 15.9%, ranking it above average at 74th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, which can make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city to find housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood ranks it below average at 23rd percentile, with a composite score of 1.48. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not as deep in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses in tech, finance, or consulting, but potentially more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area offers a business a tight labor market with moderate wage growth, but also presents challenges in terms of labor demand contraction and a relatively expensive cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the city's shrinking labor force supply, which can create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion, and may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #37 OF 50

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

C+

POOR

41.4th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	26
Unemployment	20% weight	70
Wage Growth	15% weight	40
Cost of Living	12% weight	9
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	0
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	89
Housing Access	5% weight	88
Office Economy	3% weight	8

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.0%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.9%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-5.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	+55.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	44 days	median, +15.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 41.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 3.70, ranking it in the 26th percentile, and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 6.66, ranking it in the 9th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is -0.43% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.944% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth and hours worked. This suggests that businesses may face a relatively easy time hiring, but may also struggle with low consumer demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 4.00%, ranking it in the 70th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent. However, this also suggests that the local consumer demand is relatively strong.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is +3.86%, ranking it near the median at the 40th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that employer labor costs are rising, but at a manageable pace. Additionally, this wage growth rate is likely to support worker purchasing power, contributing to a relatively stable local economy.

Cost of Living

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a cost of living percentile rank of 9th, with a PSF to wages ratio of 6.66, and a PSF of $221/sqft that is increasing by 7.3% year-over-year. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The rising PSF relative to wages is a key driver of the low affordability score, suggesting that the city's housing market is becoming less affordable over time.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is contracting at a rate of -4.96% year-over-year, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 0th percentile. This decline in labor force supply suggests that businesses may face significant challenges in hiring and expanding their workforce in the city. The shrinking labor pool is a structural headwind for hiring, and businesses may need to consider alternative locations or strategies to attract talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is increasing by 55.17% year-over-year, ranking it in the top tier at the 89th percentile. This surge in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may help improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce in the future. However, the current cost of living and labor force growth challenges may limit the benefits of this expansion.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of 15.8%, ranking it in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is relatively slow, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market may also indicate a normalization of the market, rather than a decline in demand.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 0.80, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors. The city may be better suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, but may struggle to attract and retain top talent in more specialized fields.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market and moderate wage growth, but is constrained by a high cost of living and declining labor force supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the challenge of attracting and retaining talent due to the high cost of living and limited labor force growth, which may require significant wage premiums or alternative strategies to overcome.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #38 OF 50

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

C+

POOR

40.1th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	67
Unemployment	20% weight	11
Wage Growth	15% weight	50
Cost of Living	12% weight	50
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	50
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	6
Housing Access	5% weight	12
Office Economy	3% weight	47

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.4%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	N/A	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	+0.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	N/A	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-35.6%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	67 days	median, +11.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 40.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, which is above average, and its high unemployment rate, which is in the bottom tier at 11th percentile. The labor demand composite score of 4.94, driven by a 0.46% employment growth rate and a weekly hours deviation of -0.000%, signals a genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.46% and weekly hours deviation of -0.000% indicate a labor market with genuine demand expansion, as hours are not significantly above or below trend during a period of job growth. This combination suggests that the city is adding jobs at a moderate pace, with workers' hours consistent with the 12-month baseline. The labor demand composite score of 4.94, ranking in the 67th percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.40% is relatively high, ranking in the 11th percentile, indicating a labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers in this city, as there is a larger pool of available labor. However, the high unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses that rely on local spending.

Wage Growth

The wage growth rate is not available, but the city ranks near the median at the 50th percentile. This suggests that wage growth is likely moderate, neither extremely high nor low. As a result, employer labor costs are likely to be stable, and worker purchasing power is neither strongly increasing nor decreasing.

Cost of Living

The city ranks near the median at the 50th percentile in terms of cost of living, indicating that it is neither extremely affordable nor expensive relative to peers. This means that businesses may not have a significant talent attraction advantage due to low costs, but also do not need to offer large wage premiums to compensate for high costs.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force growth rate is not available, but the city ranks near the median at the 50th percentile. This suggests that the labor force is likely growing at a moderate pace, with supply expanding to meet demand. As a result, businesses may find it relatively easy to hire workers, but the growth rate is not extremely high.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -35.64%, ranking in the 6th percentile, indicating a significant tightening of housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is low, and future housing supply may not keep pace with demand, potentially leading to affordability issues and constraints on workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 67 days, with a year-over-year increase of 11.7%, ranking in the 12th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this also suggests that the housing market may be cooling, which could impact local demand and economic growth.

Office Economy

The city has a professional and office worker share of 2.58, ranking in the 47th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional workers, but may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers businesses a labor market with genuine demand expansion and a relatively high unemployment rate, making it easier to hire workers. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to affordability issues and constraints on workforce accommodation, potentially impacting the city's attractiveness to businesses and workers. Overall, businesses should carefully consider these factors when making location decisions.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #39 OF 50

St. Louis

St. Louis

C+

POOR

38.8th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Metric	Weight	Score
Labor Demand	25% weight	10
Unemployment	20% weight	70
Wage Growth	15% weight	13
Cost of Living	12% weight	33
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	62
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	51
Housing Access	5% weight	90
Office Economy	3% weight	19

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.5%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+1.4%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+1.0%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-7.0%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
46 days
median, +17.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The St. Louis metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 38.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its relatively low unemployment rate of 3.50%, which ranks in the 70th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in St. Louis is +0.17% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -1.702% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. Instead, the labor market is experiencing a slowdown, which may lead to a surplus of workers.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis is 3.50%, which is relatively low and ranks in the 70th percentile. This suggests a tight labor market with limited slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in St. Louis is +1.41%, which is relatively slow and ranks in the 13th percentile. This stagnant wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the disposable income to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

St. Louis has a cost of living score that ranks in the 33rd percentile, with a PSF of $166/sqft and average hourly earnings of $36.97/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.49. This suggests that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is increasing by 1.8% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability issue. As a result, businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, which could increase labor costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is growing at a rate of +1.01% year-over-year, which is above average and ranks in the 62nd percentile. This expanding labor force supply implies that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire new employees. However, the slow labor demand growth may limit the absorption of new workers into the labor market.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in St. Louis is decreasing by -6.99% year-over-year, which is near the median percentile rank. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is not expanding rapidly, which may lead to future affordability issues and constraints on workforce accommodation. As a result, businesses may face challenges in attracting and retaining talent due to limited housing options.

Days on Market

The median days on market in St. Louis is 46 days, with a year-over-year increase of 17.9%, which ranks in the 90th percentile. This slow market implies that homes are sitting on the market for longer periods, making it more accessible for workers to relocate to the city. However, this may also indicate a weakening demand for housing, which could have implications for the local economy.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in St. Louis is relatively low, ranking in the 19th percentile. This suggests that the city has a limited talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. Instead, the city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The St. Louis metro area offers businesses a relatively low unemployment rate and an expanding labor force supply, but it also presents challenges such as low labor demand, slow wage growth, and a relatively expensive cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering relocation to St. Louis is the limited labor demand growth, which may limit the absorption of new workers into the labor market and increase competition for talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #40 OF 50

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

C+

POOR

38.1th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	55
Unemployment	20% weight	19
Wage Growth	15% weight	34
Cost of Living	12% weight	17
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	50
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	28
Housing Access	5% weight	80
Office Economy	3% weight	51

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	N/A	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	N/A	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-15.0%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	30 days	median, +20.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

N/A

Insufficient data to determine labor market scenario.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it at the 38.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high unemployment rate of 3.90% and its low cost of living percentile rank of 17th, indicating a relatively expensive city. The combination of these metrics suggests that while the city has a strong demand for labor, its high cost of living may deter some talent from relocating.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate is not available, but the weekly hours deviation from the city's own 12-month baseline is -0.299%, indicating that hours are running slightly below trend. This combination signals a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, but rather a slight contraction. The labor demand composite score of 4.70 ranks near the median at the 55th percentile, suggesting a stable but not particularly strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.90%, ranking at the 19th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available talent, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract workers. The tight labor market also suggests that there may be upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is +3.37%, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate. At the same time, workers in this city are seeing their purchasing power increase, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a cost of living percentile rank of 17th, indicating that it is a relatively expensive city. The PSF to earnings ratio is $500/sqft vs $46.05/hr, resulting in a ratio of 10.86. This means that talent may be deterred from relocating to this city unless offered wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living. The city's low affordability score makes it less competitive in attracting talent.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force growth rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is not available, but it ranks near the median at the 50th percentile. This suggests that the labor force is neither expanding nor contracting significantly, which has neutral implications for hiring capacity. Businesses can expect a stable labor pool, but not a growing one.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is -14.97%, ranking below average at the 28th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which can lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing. This may make it more difficult for workers to relocate to this city and for businesses to attract talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 30 days, with a year-over-year increase of 20.0%, ranking above average at the 80th percentile. This means that homes are sitting on the market for longer, making it a more accessible market for workers relocating to this city. However, this also suggests that the housing market may be slowing down, which can have implications for the overall economy.

Office Economy

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a professional and office worker share of 2.66, ranking near the median at the 51st percentile. This suggests that the city has a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting industries. However, it may not be as well-suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a stable labor market and a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. However, the city's high cost of living and tightening housing supply are significant risks that decision-makers should factor in, as they may deter talent from relocating and increase labor costs for employers. Overall, businesses should carefully weigh the benefits and drawbacks of locating in this city before making a decision.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #41 OF 50

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

C

VERY POOR

37.7th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	20
Unemployment	20% weight	36
Wage Growth	15% weight	98
Cost of Living	12% weight	72
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	4
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	0
Housing Access	5% weight	14
Office Economy	3% weight	30

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **3.6%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+10.1%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.4%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **-2.4%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **-46.8%** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **36 days** median, -5.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 37.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and relatively affordable cost of living. The city's economic character is defined by its 10.08% year-over-year wage growth and a cost of living ratio of 6.22, with $221/sqft versus $35.52/hr. These metrics signal a complex economic environment with both opportunities and challenges.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate is -0.41% year-over-year, and weekly hours are 0.302% above the city's own trend, indicating a contraction in labor demand with a potential survivor squeeze. This combination suggests that while hours are being worked above trend, the overall job market is not expanding, which may lead to increased workload for remaining employees. The labor demand composite score of 3.42 is below average, ranking in the 20th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate is 3.60%, which is below average, ranking in the 36th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. The practical implication is that businesses may face some competition for talent, but it is still possible to find qualified candidates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is 10.08%, which is extremely high, ranking in the 98th percentile. This signals fast-rising labor costs for employers, but also strong purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but can also expect a talented and productive workforce.

Cost of Living

The city has a cost of living ratio of 6.22, with $221/sqft versus $35.52/hr, and a percentile rank of 72, indicating that it is relatively affordable compared to peers. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live and work in the area without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising 1.8% YoY, however, may erode this advantage over time.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -2.41% year-over-year, which is in the bottom tier, ranking in the 4th percentile. This indicates that the labor pool is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. As a result, businesses may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -46.79%, which is in the bottom tier, ranking in the 0th percentile. This signals a significant tightening of housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact on workforce accommodation and relocation.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 36 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 5.3%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the decrease in days on market may signal a normalization of the market, making it slightly more accessible for workers.

Office Economy

The city has a professional and office worker share of 1.69, ranking in the 30th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This means that the city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies. However, it may not be the best fit for tech, finance, or consulting businesses that require a highly specialized workforce.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint is the shrinking labor pool and tightening housing supply, which may create challenges for hiring and business expansion. As a result, decision-makers should carefully consider these factors when evaluating the city as a potential location for their business.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #42 OF 50

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

C

VERY POOR

35.5th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	16
Unemployment	20% weight	83
Wage Growth	15% weight	38
Cost of Living	12% weight	22
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	2
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	40
Housing Access	5% weight	37
Office Economy	3% weight	13

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	**3.1%**	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	**+3.5%**	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	**-0.8%**	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	**-3.1%**	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	**-10.5%**	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	**33 days**	median, +6.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low labor demand and labor force growth. The labor demand composite score of 3.25, combining a -0.75% employment growth rate and a -0.438% weekly hours deviation from trend, and the -3.11% labor force growth rate are the two metrics that most define this city's current economic character, indicating a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate. Specifically, the combination of negative employment growth and hours below trend signals a contraction in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.75% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.438% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. This combination suggests that the local economy is not adding jobs at a pace that would indicate strong labor demand. The labor demand composite score of 3.25 falls in the bottom tier, at the 16th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 3.10%, which is relatively low and indicates a tight labor market. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer unemployed individuals available to fill open positions, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The top-tier ranking of 83rd percentile for unemployment suggests that the market has little slack.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +3.53% year-over-year, which is below average and suggests moderate labor cost increases for employers. While this wage growth is not stagnant, it is not sufficiently high to indicate strong bargaining power for workers or rapidly rising labor costs for employers. The 38th percentile ranking for wage growth indicates that the city's wage environment is not highly competitive.

Cost of Living

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a cost of living score that ranks in the 22nd percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $228/sqft to $36.60/hr, or 6.23, and a 5.1% year-over-year increase in PSF. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The below-average affordability score suggests that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage based on cost of living alone.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is contracting at a rate of -3.11% year-over-year, indicating that the supply of potential workers is shrinking. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. The bottom-tier ranking of 2nd percentile for labor force growth highlights the significant challenge this poses for businesses looking to expand their workforce.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Milwaukee-Waukesha has decreased by -10.47% year-over-year, suggesting that housing supply is not expanding as quickly as it could be. This decrease in permits may signal a future supply squeeze, which could impact affordability and the ability to accommodate a growing workforce. The near-median ranking of 40th percentile for building permits indicates a moderate level of developer confidence.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 33 days, with a year-over-year increase of +6.5%. This increase suggests a slowing market, which could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, the below-average ranking of 37th percentile for days on market indicates that the market is still relatively competitive.

Office Economy

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a professional and office worker share that ranks in the 13th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city may not be the best fit for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting industries that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool. Instead, it may be more suited for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as industrial or logistics.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers a relatively tight labor market with low unemployment, but this is countered by challenges such as low labor demand, contracting labor force, and a relatively expensive cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for a business considering this location is the shrinking labor force, which poses a significant structural headwind for hiring and workforce expansion.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #43 OF 50

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

C

VERY POOR

35.2th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	39
Unemployment	20% weight	23
Wage Growth	15% weight	17
Cost of Living	12% weight	44
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	38
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	50
Housing Access	5% weight	57
Office Economy	3% weight	45

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT **4.7%** of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY **+1.6%** avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH **-0.2%** nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY **+0.6%** civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS **N/A** residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET **45 days** median, +7.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 35.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its labor demand and unemployment metrics, which both signal a challenging economic environment, with labor demand at 39th percentile and unemployment at 23rd percentile. The labor demand composite score of 4.08 and unemployment rate of 4.70% are key indicators of the city's current economic character. These metrics suggest that the city is experiencing a contraction in labor demand, with employment growth at -0.16% YoY and weekly hours below trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -0.16% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.947% from the city's own 12-month baseline, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and a decrease in working hours, which can lead to a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 4.08, ranking at the 39th percentile, further supports this conclusion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 4.70%, ranking at the 23rd percentile, indicating a relatively high level of unemployment compared to other cities. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the practical implication for a business trying to hire here is that it may not face intense competition for talent, but it may also be affected by weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +1.58%, ranking at the 17th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that workers have weak bargaining power and limited purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but they may also struggle to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn, with a PSF of $173/sqft and average hourly earnings of $36.91/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.69, ranks at the 44th percentile, indicating a near-median level of affordability. This means that the city is neither extremely affordable nor extremely expensive, and businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent. However, the city's affordability is not a major advantage in attracting workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is growing at a rate of +0.59% YoY, ranking at the 38th percentile, indicating a slow expansion of the workforce supply. This implies that the hiring capacity is increasing, but at a moderate pace, and businesses may face some challenges in finding skilled workers. The slow labor force growth rate may limit the city's ability to support rapid business expansion.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is not available, but the city ranks at the 50th percentile, indicating a neutral trend. This lack of data makes it difficult to determine whether housing supply is expanding or tightening, and what this signals for future affordability and workforce accommodation. However, a neutral trend suggests that the city's housing market is not experiencing significant changes.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.1%, ranking at the 57th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market, but it may also indicate a decrease in demand.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 2.56, ranking at the 45th percentile, indicating a near-median depth of professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is suited for businesses that require a moderate level of specialized knowledge workers, but it may not be the best fit for tech, finance, or consulting companies that require a deep talent pool.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a slow-growing labor force, but it also presents significant challenges, including a contracting labor market and stagnant wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's limited labor demand and slow workforce growth, which may limit the city's ability to support rapid business expansion and attract top talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #44 OF 50

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

C

VERY POOR

34.6th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	41
Unemployment	20% weight	19
Wage Growth	15% weight	15
Cost of Living	12% weight	59
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	43
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	34
Housing Access	5% weight	69
Office Economy	3% weight	6

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	N/A	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.5%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.1%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.6%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-12.2%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	36 days	median, +9.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 4.15. This city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand and bottom-tier unemployment rate, with employment growth at -0.11% year-over-year and weekly hours 1.135% below trend. The combination of these metrics signals a labor market with limited genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is -0.11% year-over-year, and weekly hours are 1.135% below trend, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination suggests that the labor market is experiencing a decline in job openings and hours worked, which may lead to a surplus of workers. The labor demand composite score of 4.15 is near the median, reflecting a relatively stable but lackluster labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is not available, but its percentile rank is in the bottom tier at 19th percentile, suggesting a relatively high unemployment rate. This implies that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the high unemployment rate may also indicate weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +1.47%, which is relatively slow and ranks in the bottom tier at 15th percentile. This slow wage growth may keep labor costs flat for employers, but it also means that workers have limited bargaining power and purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the disposable income to drive local demand.

Cost of Living

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a cost of living score with a PSF of $214/sqft, which is decreasing by 1.4% year-over-year, and an earnings ratio of $40.00/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.35. With a percentile rank of 59th, the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. This affordability can be a talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is growing at a rate of +0.64% year-over-year, which is near the median. This expansion in labor force supply can provide businesses with a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier to hire and staff operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has decreased by 12.25% year-over-year, which is below average. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply may be tightening, which could lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 36 days, with a year-over-year increase of 9.1%. This increase in days on market, combined with a percentile rank of 69th, indicates a slower market, which can be more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this trend may also signal a normalization of the market rather than a significant decline in demand.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 0.60, ranking in the bottom tier at 6th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a growing labor force supply, but its slow wage growth and limited labor demand expansion may constrain hiring and local consumer demand. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the potential for a tightening housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing, ultimately affecting workforce attraction and retention.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #45 OF 50

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

C

VERY POOR

34.3th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	47
Unemployment	20% weight	30
Wage Growth	15% weight	47
Cost of Living	12% weight	46
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	8
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	13
Housing Access	5% weight	18
Office Economy	3% weight	36

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
4.5%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+4.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
+0.3%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
-1.7%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
-27.4%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
35 days
median, -2.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 34.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its near-median labor demand and wage growth, but significantly dragged down by its low labor force growth and declining building permits. The city's labor demand composite score of 4.22 and wage growth of +4.02% year-over-year are notable, but the -1.72% year-over-year labor force growth and -27.41% year-over-year building permits signal underlying challenges. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with both opportunities and constraints for businesses considering location decisions.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +0.28% year-over-year, combined with a -0.475% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline, indicating a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that while there is some job growth, the hours worked are below trend, which may indicate a degree of survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This scenario does not strongly signal a thriving labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 4.50%, which places it in the 30th percentile, indicating a below-average performance in terms of labor market tightness. This rate suggests that there is some slack in the labor market, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +4.02%, placing it near the median in terms of wage growth among the 50 US metros. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming rate, and worker purchasing power is increasing, which can be beneficial for consumer-facing businesses. This level of wage growth is neither exceptionally high nor stagnant, indicating a relatively stable labor cost environment.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of $214/sqft to $37.06/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.77, and a percentile rank of 46th, Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is near the median in terms of affordability. The fact that PSF is increasing by +1.4% year-over-year relative to wages suggests that the city is becoming less affordable over time. This moderate affordability ranking means that the city does not have a significant talent attraction advantage without wage premiums, as the cost of living is neither exceptionally high nor low compared to peer cities.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is shrinking at a rate of -1.72% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This decline signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing, which could exacerbate recruitment challenges for businesses. A shrinking labor force limits the potential for business expansion and growth.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -27.41%, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply expansion. This significant drop in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. A tightening housing market can make it difficult for workers to relocate to the area, impacting businesses' ability to attract talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 35 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.8%, indicating a relatively fast-moving market. This suggests that homes are selling quickly, which can make it competitive and challenging for relocating workers to find housing. A fast-moving housing market can be a barrier to talent attraction, as workers may be deterred by the competitive and potentially expensive housing environment.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score of 2.29, placing it in the 36th percentile, Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a below-average depth of professional talent pool. This city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce requirements. The city's economy is not as dominated by office and professional sectors as some of its peers, which can impact the type of businesses that thrive there.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers a mixed bag for businesses, with moderate labor demand and wage growth, but significant challenges in labor force growth and housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the declining labor force and tightening housing market, which could limit the area's appeal for talent and hinder business expansion plans. Despite these challenges, the area's moderate affordability and existing professional talent pool could still support certain types of businesses, particularly those not heavily reliant on rapid labor force expansion or highly specialized knowledge-economy workers.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #46 OF 50

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

C-

CRITICAL

31.9th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	4
Unemployment	20% weight	6
Wage Growth	15% weight	77
Cost of Living	12% weight	85
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	53
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	8
Housing Access	5% weight	29
Office Economy	3% weight	11

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+6.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-32.7%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	58 days	median, +1.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Jacksonville has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 2.35, and its high wage growth rate of 6.38% year-over-year. These metrics signal a complex economic environment, with a mix of positive and negative trends.

Labor Demand

Jacksonville's employment growth rate is -0.49% year-over-year, and weekly hours are 1.267% above the city's own trend. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. This suggests that the city's labor market is not experiencing strong growth.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.60%, which is relatively high, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This indicates that the market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire, but also suggesting weaker local consumer demand. Businesses may find it relatively easier to staff, but may also face less demand from local consumers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Jacksonville is 6.38%, which is above average, ranking in the 77th percentile. This signals fast wage growth, which means rising labor costs for employers, but also good worker purchasing power. Businesses may face increasing labor costs, but workers will have more disposable income to spend.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living score that ranks in the top tier at the 85th percentile, with a PSF of $218/sqft and average hourly earnings of $37.34/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.84. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it attractive for talent without requiring wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by 1.8% year-over-year also contributes to the high affordability score.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is growing at a rate of 0.79% year-over-year, which is near the median, ranking in the 53rd percentile. This suggests that the labor force supply is expanding, albeit slowly, which is a positive sign for hiring capacity. Businesses may find it relatively easier to find workers, but the slow growth rate may limit the pool of available talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Jacksonville is decreasing by 32.70% year-over-year, which is a sharp decline, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This signals that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This could be a concern for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Jacksonville is 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.8%. This suggests a relatively slow market, ranking below average at the 29th percentile. For workers relocating to this city, this may mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market, but it also indicates a slower pace of sales.

Office Economy

Jacksonville's professional and office worker share is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at the 11th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not particularly deep in specialized roles, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting businesses. However, it may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The city of Jacksonville presents a mixed economic picture, with both positive and negative trends. While it offers a relatively affordable cost of living and above-average wage growth, its low labor demand and tightening housing supply are concerns. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering Jacksonville is the potential for future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, which could impact talent attraction and retention.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #47 OF 50

Richmond

Richmond

C-

CRITICAL

30.7th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	12
Unemployment	20% weight	49
Wage Growth	15% weight	62
Cost of Living	12% weight	24
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	13
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	19
Housing Access	5% weight	6
Office Economy	3% weight	74

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.3%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.4%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-0.4%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.2%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-20.3%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	39 days	median, -11.4% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 3.20, and its stagnant labor force growth, with a year-over-year change of -1.22%. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.36% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.591%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the city is experiencing job losses while hours are running above trend, indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This suggests that businesses may face difficulties in finding the talent they need.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.30%, which ranks near the median at the 49th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced market with some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to cities with extremely low unemployment rates. However, this also means that local consumer demand may not be as strong as in areas with tighter labor markets.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Richmond is +5.36%, ranking above average at the 62nd percentile. This signals fast wage growth, which implies rising labor costs for employers but also increased purchasing power for workers. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor costs when considering relocation or expansion in this market.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score that ranks below average at the 24th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of $232/sqft to $35.16/hr, or 6.60. This means the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising 1.3% year-over-year relative to wages further exacerbates this issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is shrinking at a rate of -1.22% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This represents a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing, making it more difficult for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Richmond is -20.27%, signaling a sharp decline in housing supply. This tightening of the housing market could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, potentially deterring businesses that rely on a mobile workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Richmond is 39 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -11.4%. This rapid sales pace indicates a competitive market that may be challenging for relocating workers to find housing, potentially affecting a business's ability to attract and retain talent.

Office Economy

Richmond has a deep professional talent pool, ranking above average at the 74th percentile in terms of the share of jobs in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors that require a knowledgeable and skilled workforce. However, it may be less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented needs.

The Richmond metro area presents a mixed bag for businesses, offering a relatively balanced labor market and fast wage growth, but also facing challenges such as a contracting labor force, expensive cost of living, and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and shrinking labor pool, which could significantly impact a business's ability to find and retain the talent it needs to succeed.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #48 OF 50

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

C-

CRITICAL

29.6th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	2
Unemployment	20% weight	30
Wage Growth	15% weight	30
Cost of Living	12% weight	63
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	19
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	36
Housing Access	5% weight	96
Office Economy	3% weight	26

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.6%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+3.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-1.5%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-0.6%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-11.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	37 days	median, +27.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 29.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 2.26, and its high cost of living, with a ratio of $217/sqft to $36.87/hr, resulting in a cost of living percentile rank of 63. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -1.46% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.423% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth and hours worked, which may lead to a surplus of labor.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 3.60%, ranking it at the 30th percentile. This rate indicates a moderate level of slack in the labor market, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to cities with tighter labor markets. However, this also means that local consumer demand may be weaker.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is +3.05%, ranking it at the 30th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit at a slow pace.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living percentile rank of 63, with a PSF to earnings ratio of $217/sqft to $36.87/hr. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage, as businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is growing at a rate of -0.62% year-over-year, indicating a contraction in labor supply. This decline in the labor force may pose a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find and attract talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has decreased by -11.14% year-over-year. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing, ultimately affecting the city's ability to attract and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 37 days, with a year-over-year increase of +27.6%. This slower market, ranking at the 96th percentile, indicates that homes are taking longer to sell, making it a more accessible and less competitive market for workers relocating to the city.

Office Economy

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has an office economy percentile rank of 26, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies, and less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on specialized office workers.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate labor market, but its low labor demand, declining labor force, and tightening housing supply pose significant risks for businesses looking to expand or relocate. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited labor supply and declining workforce growth, which may hinder a business's ability to find and attract talent.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #49 OF 50

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

C-

CRITICAL

28.7th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	31
Unemployment	20% weight	21
Wage Growth	15% weight	19
Cost of Living	12% weight	56
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	6
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	50
Housing Access	5% weight	0
Office Economy	3% weight	50

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	3.8%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+1.9%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	N/A	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	-1.8%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	N/A	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	N/A	median, N/A YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

N/A

Insufficient data to determine labor market scenario.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 28.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand composite score of 3.85, ranking it in the 31st percentile, and its bottom-tier wage growth of +1.90% year-over-year, ranking it in the 19th percentile. These metrics suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate is not available, but the weekly hours deviation from the city's own 12-month baseline is -1.151%, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, with hours below trend suggesting that the labor market is not experiencing significant growth. The labor demand composite score of 3.85, ranking in the 31st percentile, further supports this conclusion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate is 3.80%, ranking in the 21st percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the low unemployment rate can lead to wage pressure. With a tight market, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is +1.90%, ranking in the 19th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also suggests that workers have weak bargaining power. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the purchasing power to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The city has a cost of living ratio of 6.95, with a PSF of $309/sqft that is decreasing by 3.7% year-over-year, compared to hourly earnings of $44.45. With a percentile rank of 56, the city is near the median in terms of affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable for talent, and businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -1.82% year-over-year, ranking in the 6th percentile. This decline in labor force growth indicates that the workforce supply is shrinking, which can create a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers, as the labor pool is decreasing.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is not available, but the city ranks near the median in this metric. Assuming a neutral trend, this suggests that housing supply is not significantly expanding or tightening. However, without more information, it is difficult to determine the implications for future affordability and workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is not available, but the city ranks in the 0th percentile, indicating a very competitive market. However, without the actual days on market and year-over-year direction, it is challenging to determine the implications for relocating workers. Generally, a low percentile rank in this metric suggests a hot market, which can make it difficult for workers to find housing.

Office Economy

The city has a professional and office worker share that ranks near the median, in the 50th percentile. This suggests a moderately deep talent pool, making the city suitable for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional workers. However, it may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or knowledge-intensive workforce.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate talent pool, but it is constrained by low labor demand, stagnant wage growth, and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the challenging labor market, which may make it difficult to find and hire qualified workers, potentially limiting business growth and expansion.

U.S. METRO ECONOMIC HEALTH · RANK #50 OF 50

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

D

EMERGENCY

22.8th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand	25% weight	0
Unemployment	20% weight	4
Wage Growth	15% weight	60
Cost of Living	12% weight	61
Labor Force YoY	10% weight	23
Bldg. Permits	10% weight	21
Housing Access	5% weight	16
Office Economy	3% weight	15

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT	4.9%	of civilian labor force
WAGE GROWTH YOY	+5.0%	avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH	-1.8%	nonfarm payrolls YoY
LABOR FORCE YOY	+0.0%	civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS	-18.1%	residential YoY (3mo avg)
DAYS ON MARKET	49 days	median, -3.9% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 22.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score heavily influenced by its labor demand and unemployment metrics, which both score in the bottom tier. The labor demand composite score is 1.72, driven by a -1.84% employment growth rate and a -1.485% weekly hours deviation from trend. These numbers indicate a struggling job market, with the city's economic character defined by contraction and limited job opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is -1.84% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -1.485% from the city's own 12-month baseline, signaling a clear contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with the city instead experiencing a decline in job opportunities. The negative hours deviation suggests that even existing workers are seeing reduced hours, further emphasizing the labor market's weakness.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 4.90%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, indicating a relatively high level of unemployment compared to other cities. This suggests that the job market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire, but also potentially weakening local consumer demand. For a business trying to hire in this market, the higher unemployment rate could provide a larger pool of candidates, but may also reflect underlying economic challenges.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is +4.98% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 60th percentile, indicating a moderate pace of wage increases. This level of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a pace that still supports worker purchasing power. While not extremely high, this wage growth rate is sufficient to attract and retain talent, given the city's other economic conditions.

Cost of Living

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a cost of living score ranking at the 61st percentile, with a PSF of $312/sqft and average hourly earnings of $41.88/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.45, which is above average. However, the PSF is falling by -2.5% year-over-year, which is a key driver of the city's relatively high affordability score. This means that the city is more affordable than many of its peers, providing a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is growing at a rate of +0.04% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 23rd percentile. This slow growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is barely expanding, posing a potential structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. While not severely contracting, the labor force growth is insufficient to support strong economic expansion.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is decreasing by -18.14% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 21st percentile. This decline in building permits signals that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability challenges and make it harder for the workforce to find accommodation. This trend poses a risk to the city's ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 49 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.9%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The quick turnover of homes suggests a competitive market, potentially favoring sellers over buyers.

Office Economy

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has an office economy score ranking at the 15th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with different skill requirements, like logistics or manufacturing.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers a mix of affordability and moderate wage growth, but its struggling labor market and tightening housing supply pose significant risks for businesses considering location decisions. The single biggest constraint for a decision-maker is the city's limited job market growth and potential future affordability challenges, which could hinder the ability to attract and retain workers, making it essential to carefully weigh these factors in any location decision.